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There Can Be Only One Morning Shift

by Fude-san

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Prologue: What She Brought From Seattle

The thing about growing up in Seattle, Jennifer had decided somewhere around age fourteen, was that it calibrated you for a certain kind of gray. Not depressing gray, a purposeful gray, the gray of a sky that was doing something, moving somewhere, carrying weather from one place to the next. Seacouver had the same quality. That was probably why it had felt like home inside of two weeks. She packed the car in three hours, which was about two hours and fifty minutes longer than the actual packing took and ten minutes of standing in the parking lot of the apartment complex on Capitol Hill looking up at the window of the place she'd lived for two years, deciding whether she felt anything about leaving it. She didn't, particularly. That was useful information. The things she brought: a duffel bag of clothes, which ran heavily toward flannel shirts, worn jeans, band t-shirts in various states of age and one good jacket. A backpack with her laptop, her textbooks, and notebooks she'd been filling since she was fifteen. A box of records, actual vinyl, because her cousin had given her a turntable when she turned seventeen. Jennifer had built the collection one thrift store

at a time. A drum practice pad and a pair of sticks. A coffee maker, a good one, purchased used from a musician who was moving to New York and couldn't fit it in the van. Her skateboard — old, scuffed, Capitol Hill stickers. She didn't bring the boyfriend. That had ended in February. Jennifer had afforded herself the time to conclude that the relationship had been comfortable rather than right. Those were two different things. What she was going toward: a city she'd been to twice, a bartending job she'd gotten over the phone, an apartment she'd found on a listing site and had ponied up first and last month's sight unseen. The price was right, the neighborhood was walkable and at times a decision just had to be made. Jennifer got to Seacouver at three in the afternoon. Her apartment was on the third floor and smelled like the previous tenant's candles. She put the coffee maker on the kitchen counter first, then the turntable and then the records. She made the bed and hung her flannel shirts in the closet. Jennifer sat on the floor with a cup of coffee and looked up the bar she was supposed to start at on Monday Joe's Bar: good reviews, jam sessions on Thursdays. The owner was mentioned in one piece in a local arts paper. There was a picture of him standing in front of the stage, leaning on a cane with a genuine smile.

Joe's Bar

Jennifer showed up Monday at 3:50, ten minutes ahead of her in-person interview time. On time was early. The rest of it came after. Joe's BarJoe Dawson hired her in four minutes. Jennifer knew it was four minutes because she had looked at the clockwhen she walked in — the reflex of someone who timed things, who kept track, who had learned that the intervals between moments were often asinformative as the moments themselves. It was 3:50 pm when shepushed through the door. Joe asked two questions: How long did you work in Seattle? Can youhandle a Thursday night crowd alone? She'd answered both truthfully — two years and yes, she could handle acrowd. Obviously it was easier with back-up but she

had put down a fewuprisings in her time. Jennifer asked if he wanted details. Joe declined. For someone who had just entered the lower-level checkered-floor gin joint the applicant was confident without being arrogant. Joe had a sense of her right away; good stock and mostlikely a good hire. Over time Jennifer learned that Joe looked ateveryone the same way. He had the specific patience of a man who had spentdecades watching people, and who had learned to trust what the watchingtold him."All right, I'll see you tomorrow," Joe announced but his new hire didnot move. "Something else? I don't think I have anything here for youthat isn't a soft drink."Old enough to serve, not old enough to enjoy. "Coffee?" "Coming right up," Joe answered before stepping away. He caught herstaring at the stage. "You play?"She nodded and thanked him. "Yeah, that's really what drew me to yourplace. There's a lot of blues history here. It's almost a shrine."Joe chuckled. "We worship daily." And then Jennifer forced herself to ask. "I was hoping you'd consider lettingme stay to get acquainted. My classes don't start for another anotherten days and I had to put down first and last months rent.""Mondays are usually pretty slow around here, usually just me and Leon," Joereturned gesturing to the kitchenShe continued her plea. "My student aide won't come through until thebeginning of next month," Jennifer added. "I promise I won't get in theway and I'll work for tips ."It didn't feel like a hustle. Before him was a young woman who justneeded to get a few bucks in her pocket. "Sure, let me see you interactwith some of the customers."Monday ended up being somewhat successful, especially when Joe let hertake the wheel. Jennifer left the bar with over forty bucks in herpocket and felt like a millionaire. She spent it all at the grocerystore: quality coffee beans, whole milk, sturdy crackers, creamy peanutbutter and one luxury box of Camels. With the change she had leftJennifer paused by the gum ball machines and weighed her options:candy, temporary tattoos or one of those super bouncy balls that defiedthe laws of physics. After turning the crank she received a plasticcontainer holding a cerulean blue ball. She examined it and thought itmight be an example of what the earth would look like if it was just onebig sea of blue. When Jennifer returned to her apartment she found a stowaway lime amidher groceries. She decided to name him Stowie and promptly elevated hisrank to admiral of the refrigerator, Admiral

Stowie. She put the blueball next to Stowie so neither would be alone. The first week at Joe's was just work and between a call-out and the firstimpressions Jennifer had created, Joe let her come in every day. She learned the layout — speed rack configured left, well glasseson the right, the spot under the register where Joe kept the good Scotchfor specific occasions. She asked what qualified as a special occasionand he said he'd let her know. Being there several days in a rowJennifer was meeting the regulars, getting to know their names, theirpreferred libations and made relevant small talk. She saw the patterns ofa bar that had been running long enough to have rhythms. It was the fourth day, Thursday May 9th, when the tall man came into thepicture. He arrived at five, was light on his feet on the stairs andplanted himself at the right end of the bar. It was clear by his bodylanguage that the newcomer was the owner of that spot. Joe brought him aScotch without asking. They said each other's names — Mac, Joe — withthe compression of people who'd been doing that a long time. The mancalled Mac did a sweep of the room that she'd later learn was automaticand ingrained, a habit of someone who'd been reading rooms for a verylong time. He looked at her. Jennifer looked back. She was wiping down the bar and shedidn't stop or make anything of it."New," he said to Joe. Not a question."Just started on Monday," Joe said. "So far, so good.""Just a few days?" In Mac's opinion the new bartender looked like shehad been there since the grand opening. She blended, fit in well. Helooked at her again and caught her attention. "I'm Duncan MacLeod. And Ithink you've got Joe wrapped around your finger already.""Competence recognizes competence," Jennifer returned before introducingherself. "Jennifer Marsh, fresh in from Seattle.""Welcome Jennifer Marsh fresh in from Seattle."Jennifer finished the section she was tending to and moved to the next. "Youwant anything else or is Scotch the plan?"Mac smiled. Jennifer took that as an indicator to keep his glass full.*Real, warm and a nice smile.*"Scotch," he said, "is always the starting point."Jennifer moved down the bar, served two other people and did aneffortless check back. Mac noticed the effort. "Thank you, Jennie," hesaid, without looking up from his phone. Jennifer kept moving and wiped down the next section. She did not lookback at Mac for a full minute and when she did he was still readingsomething on his phone. The man had Scotch

at his elbow and was entirelyunaware that he'd said anything particular. Jennifer was aware. She had felt it land: the Scottish accent and thediminutive of her name, easy and unthought, like it had been in hismouth before he opened it. It was simply what he called her. It was akind of deja vu she had never experienced until that night. *No one calls me Jennie.*The rest of the shift went smoothly and nothing of major concernoccurred. Joe said he wanted her to count the till and Mac realized itwas time to settle up. “How much do I owe you?” Jennifer looked to Joe for answer. “I’m sorry, I don’t know how youhandle tabs for your friends.”“Some of my friends pay nothing, some I give a discount and some Idouble charge,” Joe returned. She had heard variations of that joke inthe past. “Mac’s in that first group. He drinks for free.” Jennifer madea mental note and raised the bar to friendship. They were soldiers in arms,perhaps, maybe family. Mac had his wallet open and put a fifty on the bar top. Grant. Fifty dollars. She could get a week of groceries if she planned itcorrectly. “Oh, that’s entirely too much. I can’t accept it.”“Perfectly good money,” Mac said with a smile. She gave him a firm andfinal refusal. Mac put the bill back in his wallet and offered asolution. “How about I take you out to lunch tomorrow? Or give you thenickel tour of the city?”*Is this a date? Is this man asking me out on a date?*“Not necessary, especially if you’re a regular around here.”Joe shook his head. “Well, if you’re not going to show up for a freelunch I will,” Joe commented. “What time were you thinking?”“Noon works for me,” Mac stated before looking back to Jennifer. “Let metake you to lunch. It’s clear you need a little financial help,otherwise you wouldn’t be throwing your last days of summer away tendingbar.”She felt an urge, a push to accept. Joe’s comment sealed the deal.“Mac’s a good man. Go to lunch. It’s not like he’s going to abscond withmy new employee.”Abscond. Words made a huge difference when peppered into conversationlike that. Those were destiny changing words. Jennifer gathered up her things and asked Joe if she could take a to-go cupto finish off the coffee. He waved her on and watched as she leaved.“I don’t know what just happened here but I can tell you, this doesn’thappen often.”Mac nodded. “She’s special,” he commented before sending out a grouptext.*I just met someone new at Joe’s. Try to make it down here this week ifyou can. She’s, she’s something else

The Skate Park

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Jennifer was waiting outside of Joe's with a board under her right arm,her bag and a cigarette burning. She had convinced herself that if thelunch date didn't work out that it would still be a good day. She hadenjoyed the ride to Joe's as the free-time fun she had been craving. The weatherwas perfect and Jennifer had work for the rest of the week. No going hungry."Nice deck." She turned and saw Mac coming around the corner. "Car'saround back."He waited for her and then made certain that she had the space closer tothe building as her path. It was Jennifer's turn to comment. "Nice car,"she commented. There was only one car in the back lot and it was abeautiful Thunderbird. "Is this a 57?""It is," Mac confirmed. He opened the car door for her, closed it andsat behind the wheel. "Ready?" "Where?"Once they were underway Mac took the opportunity at a stop light to turnon the radio and adjusted the dial. "What kind of music do you like?""All kinds, you name it. Blues, jazz, rock, grunge, what people callClassical and of course movie soundtracks." Mac noted that she had veryeclectic tastes and let the dial fall chaotically. CCR was instantlyadding to the carefree mood. Jennifer put an addendum on her answer. "All kinds, but not smooth jazz.""All right, no smooth jazz," he echoed with a grin. Mac wasn't sure ifthat was a joke or a fact, but it was funny either way. The T-Bird rolled into the Sea Cow parking lot and he selected a spotnear the back of the restaurant. Mac set his arm briefly on the passengerseat so he could turn his head and back into the spot. Jenniferinstinctively moved out of the way. *Get away parking.*Once parked Jennifer was trying to figure the logistics of opening thedoor with all of her gear on her right shoulder. Mac stepped around thecar, opened the door and even offered a hand to help her step out of hischariot. *I could get used to this. I could really get used to this.*Mac continued to lead the procession, held

the door open for an exitingcouple and then ushered Jennifer through the vestibule. He stepped up tothe host stand and requested a table for two. The manager showed them toa table, Jennifer sat first and put all of her gear to the side on the long benchseat. Mac naturally sat across from her, scanned the room and then picked upthe menu. He already knew what he wanted but it felt like the rightthing to do."What's good here aside from the fries?" "Unfortunately it's all good," Mac said with a grin. "You really can't go wrong."She nodded. "What's the budget?" A bus boy set two glasses of water onthe table and a waitress followed. She asked if they wanted coffee. Jennifer said yes, Mac reversed his cup and said he would be fine withwater. Once it was just the two of them again Jennifer repeated thequestion. "What's the budget today?""Order whatever you want, no budget," Mac answered. "I'm happy you cameout. Let's enjoy ourselves."She looked at him blankly. "All right, I'm going to order a Coke toowith my meal.""I'll take the hit," Mac chuckled. "So, you said you're from Seattle and that you have classes coming up. What are you studying?"Jennifer was about to answer when the waitress returned to take their order. She asked about the possibility of a veggie burger, settled on a grilled chicken sandwich instead with fries and requested a Coke with a lot of ice. Mac went with the standard lettuce, tomato and mustard burger. He indicated he also wanted fries. The waitress nodded, took the menus and departed."So, you were going to tell me about your new course of study." Helistened as Jennifer went into the detailed plan that she had beenbuilding since she had made the decision to aim for a career in LibrarySciences. Jennifer had purposely started at a community college to getthe basics out of the way; just as informative and at half the price. She ended her five year plan by stating that she was entertaininga Master's Degree, maybe even a PhD, but everything hinged on hersuccessfully receiving the first degree. Mad nodded. "One step at a time, that's how it's done."Jennifer agreed and shifted the focus to Mac. "What about yourself? Whatdo you do with your free time other than take out strange women tolunch?""You're not that strange, not Portland-strange anyway."," Mac commentedwhich generated a smile. "I deal in antiquities mostly and co-manage adojo.""A dojo, like a martial arts dojo?"Mac confirmed that was exactly what he meant. "Are you familiar withmartial arts?""No, not

really. I took a few free self-defense classes at the Y to giveme an edge at my previous job." Mac asked if that previous job had alsobeen bartending and Jennifer said it had been. She had started as a barback naturally, shadowed a real talent, rose up the ranks and was theweekend lead before she put in her resignation. "If you can picture aheavy metal bar attended mostly by privileged college students from UWalong with some of the friendlier motorcycle clubs, you'd know what myweekends looked like for the last two years."Mac was trying to sort through his mental catalog of drinking establishmentsbut his train of thought was interrupted when two gigantic, oval whiteplates were served. Both Jennifer and Mac agreed that everything lookedright and waitress told them to flag her down if they needed anything. "Sounds rough," Mac commented as he set both hands on his burger. Henoted that Jennifer went straight to the fries."Rough place but I had some quality bouncers and a good team that had my back," Jennifer responded continuing to ignore the sandwich. "Joe's is definitely a step up for me, much cleaner and so far, classier clientele.""We aim to please." *Why isn't she eating the sandwich?*"Which disciplines are taught at your dojo?""Everything," Mac answered before listing some of the options. "Whatinterests you?""As it turns out, I'm interested in everything," Jennifer responded with a smile. She raised her hand to get the waitress's attention to get a box for the sandwich.*She's not going to eat the sandwich here because she's going to save itfor dinner or for after a shift at Joe's. These purse strings are tight.*"I had a couple of thoughts on where we might go, depending on yourneeds."Jennifer closed up the cover on her next meal and insisted that he hadbeen more than generous to take her out to lunch. Mac countered that hehad been her age once where every penny counted, had been fortunateenough to earn a living and believed in sharing the wealth. Jennifer got flustered trying to juggle her pride, her need and her curiosity overthis new person, this new unusual person, that had just popped into herlife. "I have a really hard time asking for help," she finally blurtedin response. Her face flashed and she quickly regained composure. "I'msorry, that was, that just slipped out.""But, it's true," Mac parried. "You don't have to ask. I'm here. I wantto help. What do you need for your apartment?"Jennifer wanted to answer that she needed an apartment for her apartment, but agree that a few

things wouldn't hurt. From her general list of needs Mac decided the big box outlet was the correct choice. Jennifer hesitantly placed basics in the cart before attempting to remove items once she saw the price tags. "Stop that or I'll just start knocking things into this cart and go get another one."Jennifer took direction easily and ceased to censor the items she had taken from the shelves. Once they had loaded up on paper products Mac steered them into general home merchandise. "Give me an idea of the layout." Jennifer described her apartment as a box that had a bed and a few personal items strewn about. "That is strangely how I would describe my loft as well," he chuckled. "How are you on kitchen supplies?""A couple of coffee cups, a couple bowls, my coffee set-up, a record player and my grinder of course." Mac cracked that he couldn't wait to hear about her furniture situation. "Oh, that's covered. The place came with a bed."That wasn't a joke. Jennifer clearly had just rode her board directly from Seattle with what she could carry. "Well, they have these combo sets they sell now, four plates, four bowls, four coffee cups.""I can only drink out of one cup at a time." *True and wise beyond her years.* Mac noted it and assumed that she didn't have any silverware that wasn't plastic and made her chose between two different designs. When Mac started asking questions about pots and pans a little more sand fell out of the glass. "I, I really don't know how to cook. I don't need those.""What if I want to come over and cook eggs?"Challenge accepted. "Dinner or breakfast?" she returned. Mac picked a box and set it in the cart. He was intent on helping her get all the tools she would need. The only aisle that she didn't not debate was the one that offered coffee. Once there, Jennifer put on a master class. She pointed out the three best options she saw for whole bean coffee, the ground brands that would do in a pinch and had a lot to say about Nescafe. Jennifer had basically been thinking aloud about how she planned to go about choosing a bag from the selection. She had brought a few customers to a stop with her announced preferences regarding coffee growing parts of the world. When one woman actually asked the lecturer a question, Jennifer pulled out her coffee notebook and happily shared what she knew. She encouraged the woman to take a picture of the coffee log. *A natural leader, a teacher, vibrant when she's in her element. Who is this woman and why has she landed here? This is not just chance.*Once

proper beans had been selected they continued down the warehouse aisle into the coffee brewers proper. “Ah, there is it, the bane of my existence,” Mac commented as they eased down the aisle. Jennifer followed his eye line and froze. “You have a Jura? You own a Jura and it’s sitting in your house right now?” Mac confirmed he did. “I might just have to let you come over and make eggs.”“The machine does not like me,” Mac announced. “It’s a hostile relationship.”She just shook her head. “Well, if you ever consider getting a divorce let me know.” Mac chuckled audibly. She restated it in her head and then attempted to apologize, as if she had crossed some kind of line. Mac found there was a real ebb and flow, clear and full of wisdom followed by periods of reluctance and fear.“I suppose this would be good time to ask if you are married,” Jennifer commented.“No, not married, no kids.” She said she was in the same boat before asking for the time. Mac noted that she did not have a watch. “Well, it’s after three and it’s going to be a mad house checking out. What time does Joe want you at the bar tonight?”After a few calculations Mac grabbed a few more pantry items, a Stanley thermos, travel cup and dish soap. “We’ll look at the fresh produce and personal products next time.”*Next time? We’re going to do this again? Who is this guy?*Mac had sent a direct text to Richie requesting his assistance, if possible, at Joe’s. Scheduled classes at the dojo had finished for the dinner hours. Richie dropped everything, locked up and was waiting when Mac and his passenger arrived with a car full of stuff. Richie had received the text about the new woman at Joe’s when it had been sent. He didn’t realize that he was about to meet her on the spot.“What happened, Mac, did you hit a fire sale? One day only, everything must go?” Richie commented before introducing himself. “I’m Richie Ryan.” “Jennifer Marsh,” she returned. As she freed herself from the car he made mention of her board. “You shred?”Richie confirmed that he did indeed shred and suggested that they hit the skate park together at some point. She nodded and agreed. It was a date. “Is this all for the bar?” Richie questioned as he started grabbing items from the trunk.“It’s all going in the bar, back room for now, but these are Jennie’s items,” Mac answered simply. She silently thanked him for not adding that he had gone out of his way to pay for it all. It was hard enough to accept the help never mind find the help advertised. Richie didn’t make anything

of it. Mac was a helpful guy, especially when it came to women. As she stood next to him unpacking the trunk Richie continued the small talk. “So, you’re the new bartender Joe was talking about.”“I am indeed,” she returned. “What’s your drink?”“Depends on the time of day,” Richie answered as he and Jennifer started walking to the bar. Mac had propped open the door which made the unloading and loading flow easily. “I need to get back to work shortly, a few more classes to go, but when it’s quitting time there’s nothing quite like a chilled long neck, especially in the summer.”“Classes as in dojo classes?” Jennifer questioned. “You’re Mac’s co-manager?”“Mac’s my co-manager,” Richie insisted as he turned on the charm. “But yes, manager of DeSalvo’s and we have two more classes before we close tonight.”“And what are you doing afterward?”“Depends on if you’ll have a chilled long neck for me.” She assured him she would, thanked him for the assistance and sent him back to work with a fresh cup of coffee from the bar. Richie Ryan: cream, two sugars.*That man has the most incredible eyes I have ever seen. I could drown in those eyes.

The Wrist Lock and the Dojo

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Once all of the purchases had been handled Jennifer went through the routine she had constructed over the week. She checked everything, twice, to be certain they had everything clean and ready to go. She had a full bin of ice, all bottled items stocked fully, especially one bottle she marked as reserved. Joe wasn’t anywhere to be found but Leon was in the kitchen ready to help. “And me as well, if needed,” Mac offered. Jennifer turned to thank him, checked his glass and then stumbled a bit on what to call him. “Thank you-” “Mac,” he insisted. “My friends call me Mac.”“Mac it is,” Jennifer replied. It was a Thurs-

day, jam night and she remembered Joe asking her if she could take on a Thursday night crowd on her own. She speculated that it was going to be that night.A strange character of a man entered while she was checking on stage business. Everything was plugged in correctly and ready to roll. The band would take it from there. Jennifer went back to the bar and on the way noticed that the newcomer was sitting near Mac, at least, a friend. He gave off the same vibes she had been feeling around Mac all day as well as the dojo co-manager, Richie. This new character ordered a draft beer without offering a greeting. Jennifer assessed him quickly; eyes that had seen too much and a face that had decided not to show it. And then he put his feet on the bar. Jennifer removed them; without looking up, without comment, without breaking the rhythm of what she was doing. Mac audibly chuckled. She was already moving to the next customer when she felt attention shift — not toward her exactly, but toward the fact that the thing the newcomer had done had produced a specific and immediate result. Apparently Jennifer had met some criterion she hadn't known she was being tested against. It was disturbing as much as it was amusing."You're new," Methos said."Started on Monday," Jennifer replied. If Mac's friend wasn't going to introduce himself she figured it wasn't necessary to do the same as the place was really beginning to fill up. Music had been advertised as starting at seven and Jennifer knew that meant half past the hour, at best. She kept the drinks rolling like she was an assembly line and everyone seemed relatively comfortable. It was a relief to see Joe enter through the back. "Ah, good. I thought this might be a test.""Not a test but if it was I'd say you've done beautifully," Joe commented as he scanned the entire bar. There were no empty glasses, not a one, and she obviously had been bussing and serving simultaneously. "Take a break. It's about to ramp up in here."Jennifer took ten, enough time to hit the restroom and the alley for a few puffs. By the time she was back behind the rail it felt like she had never left."So, this is the amazing new woman," Methos commented. "A little on the younger side for you, McLeod, but I can see the appeal. She certainly has everything that counts where it counts.""We had lunch yesterday. Jennie's a nice girl."Methos shrugged. "With a crowd like this your Jennie should make a killing." "Why is there a long neck in the cooler with a reserved tag?" Joe questioned when Jennifer

flew past him with a tub of glasses.“Because it’s reserved,” Jennifer answered quickly and flatly before she continued filling orders before the music began. Once the house band started the crowd chatter was outmatched. Jennifer picked up a bounce in her step to the twelve bar blues. She wanted to slow down, to watch a few people play, but work was work. Richie, dojo co-manager, showed up just as the second set was starting. “Oh, bar maid, I’d like an ale please.”“You got it, Richie,” Jennifer returned before pulling the reserved beer out of the cooler. She uncapped it and offered a glass. Richie declined the glass but was touched by the little sign she had taped onto a bottle, just for him.“Hmm, maybe she’s actually not your girl, after all,” Methos announced as he watched the short interaction between Richie and the new girl. They were falling over themselves on a sticker, on a beer bottle.“She’s not anyone’s girl, Methos,” Mac countered. “But you can’t deny there isn’t something different about her. I can’t put my finger on it.”“Everything will be revealed in time, Mac, everything in time.”

Methos

Methos returned the following Tuesday. He put his feet on the bar. Jennifer removed them. Same result: no comment, no pause, no acknowledgment beyond the removal itself. On the third Tuesday Jennifer was ready for it, not performing readiness, just awareness, and she had his feet off the bar before he'd fully settled them. Jennifer heard him chortle and wasn’t sure if that was laughing at or with. The whole bar had heard him chortle. Jennifer filed the dossier on Methos focusing first on the way he read everything: phone, book, occasionally a newspaper folded with origami precision. The fact that he had put his

feet on the bar three weeks in a row and she had removed them every single time was burned into her brain. Neither of them had said a word about it. By the fourth week it was no longer a test. It was shorthand, their established new shorthand, that read, 'I see you, you see me, we have an understanding, now let's get on with it.'He called her Marsh on the fourth week, in a different register, Methos had updated her from new bartender to something more like a person he had assessed and found acceptable. Jennifer did not say anything about this, but wondered who he had pestered to learn her name.* * *Fitz came in the third week like weather. Jennifer was immediately amused but didn't know why. Fitz put both hands on the bar, looked at her as though he had just won the lottery and asked the ultimate question. "When are we running away together, darling girl?""As soon as my shift is over," Jennifer returned. Fitz reached for her hand, placed a gentle kiss and then executed a charming gesticulation."What might your name be?""It might be Jennifer Marsh but I supposed that depends on who is asking.""I'm Hugh Fitzcairn. Everyone calls me Fitz. Give me the good whisky and I'll tell you how I won my name."Jennifer quickly checked the notes Joe had given her detailing the guests she should just serve and not charge. Fitz was on the list. She gave him the good whisky as requested and Fitz shared his story. When Jennifer was able to take out her journals and write she labeled him as charming. The only name left on her crib notes was Amanda. One more and the whole gang would be there.

Amanda

Amanda arrived and while Jennifer felt the something she had noticed when Joe's friends appeared, it was much more mellow, noticeable but mellow and low in regis-

ter. “You must be Amanda.”“You must be Jennifer,” Amanda returned as she settled on a seat at the bar. “I’ve heard a lot about you and am so glad I get to meet you today.”Jennifer was a little flustered and couldn’t help but wonder what the lady was trying to sell her.“I wanted to know if you were worthy of the room."“And?" Jennifer said. “Don’t keep me waiting."I watched you hold the bar alone on two separate occasions and I’ve seen you handle nine difficult situations with finesse. And the face Mac has when contemplating you without you knowing is quite something.”When an answer did not appear Jennifer asked Amanda for her drink order. She then opened a Pinot Gris, offered Amanda the cork and a sample. It wasn’t her usual protocol in a bar to go through that routine, but it was slow and Amanda struck her as a woman that would appreciate the gesture.“You're worthy of the room," Amanda said after thanking her for the wine. "More than worthy. The room is yours. I just wanted to know before I decided how much I liked you."“And you’re here to tell me your decision?” Jennifer felt like only half of the conversation was in English."I like you very much," Amanda said. "Which I find slightly annoying, for reasons that have nothing to do with you."They talked for an hour. Amanda told her three things about Mac — nothing private, nothing that crossed a line, just the texture of someone who had known him for a while. And while it was nice to get some background on Mac, the reason Amanda felt compelled to share it with her was unclear. When she was able to jot some notes in her journal about Amanda, Jennifer just wrote the word: WHAT?! Chapter Two — The Wrist-Lock and the DojoThe incident happened on Wednesday, June 12th. Jennifer was working alone on the slow end of an evening shift when the man three stools down from Mac decided that her arm was something he was entitled to grab. It wasn’t. The moment the patron’s hand touched her skin she removed it. From there, Jennifer executed a basic, outward wrist rotation. In two seconds she had removed his hand and had his wrist at an angle that was uncomfortable. She stepped back and said, "Don't."He didn't. She went back to work. Jennifer was aware, without looking, that Mac had seen the entire encounter. His quality of attention was different from others, in and out of the small circle of Joe’s friends. Mac’s interest was complete, patient and genuine. She'd felt the attention shift when the man

grabbed her arm and she'd felt it stay but relax as she handled it. Jennifer didn't look at Mac. She served the next person. At close, when only Joe and Mac were left, Mac asked, ”Where did you learn that?""Seattle," she said knowing he probably wasn’t looking for a geographical reply. She was counting the till and was not about to be distracted.“That class you mentioned at the Y?” Jennifer replied that the one class had been enough for its intended purposes. She stated that she knew what she knew, and was more than aware of the things she did not. "Do you want to know more?"She looked up and stared at him for a moment. “I always want to know more.”“If you want to train properly, I'll teach you." Mac paused. "In exchange for help to clean the dojo. It's a large space and we recently lost our cleaning crew. Bringing you in would save me a lot of time and energy. I’ve seen your work ethic.”Nothing transactional beyond the cleaning was implied. “What do you think I should learn first?” “It’s always best to start with the basics and build out from there."This was it, that was the moment of clarity he had been waiting to receive. Joe’s new bartender had been dropped into Mac’s lap so that he could train her. She didn’t read as a pre-immortal to him so the why was still hidden, but clearly that was the role he had been assigned.“Let me get my book.” Jennifer opened her army surplus bag and pulled out a black and white composition notebook. From the other side of the bar Mac could see that she had a colored coordinated masterpiece that placed every activity in life on paper. “Are we keeping the schedule as is, Joe?”“That works for me. You’re the one with this thing of commitments. Do you even have an empty space to stuff training in there as well?”"Tuesday mornings.” Mac and Jennifer had reached the same answer simultaneously. “This all may get rearranged when classes start, but as of now, I can do Tuesday mornings.”"Good." He finished his Scotch. He stood."Mac," she called out before he had a chance to leave. “Is there aprotocol I should know before I show up?"* * *The dojo was on Morrison Street, a converted industrial building. DeSalvo's Martial Arts was still faintly visible on the exterior. Jennifer arrived on Tuesday, June 18th just before eight in the morning. The street door was unlocked. Jennifer let herself in and from the hallway she could see that Mac was already there, in training clothes, doing something with a wooden sword. She would later learn it was called a bokken and

that Mac had years of practice. Jennifer remained in the hallway. She didn't want to interrupt and figured Mac would greet her when he was ready."Shoes off before you cross the threshold," he said. "Always. The floor is sacred space."Jennifer set down her bag, removed her shoes and saw there was a pair near the door lined up neatly to the wall. She placed hers next to them."Bow when you enter," Mac said. "Not to me specifically. To the space. The bow is an acknowledgment that you're entering somewhere that requires a different quality of attention than the rest of the day."Jennifer turned back to the threshold. She bowed; a small, genuine act of respect, that communicated she was taking it seriously. "Good. The same when you leave."Jennifer entered and went to the center of the training space. There were clean lines built into the structure, some weapons parked on the wall and high windows. The space was large and well-maintained. "The cleaning," Jennifer said. "What needs doing?""We'll get into that later. Come stand here facing me and bow in." Mac explained the process of bowing in and how the practice changed depending on the type of class or lesson that was using the space. For their purposes a short bow from her to her teacher would suffice countered by a return bow reaffirming the commitment to the purpose. "I will teach you everything I know, for as long as you want to learn."*I karate teach, you karate do.*"I agree to those terms, opposite and inverse," Jennifer announced. "I will learn everything you can teach me for as long as you want to train me."Mac sat, cupped both hands over his sternum and instructed her to do the same. "This is how we'll start and end our lessons. Calm yourself, slow your breathing and clear your mind. Close your eyes and focus on your breath. When you can feel, better yet, when you can hear your heartbeat, this is the mantra I am giving you today: I am still. I can hear my heartbeat. When you're centered and ready, you'll stand and we'll begin."Jennifer calmly found her center and repeated the mantra in her mind. Three times felt correct. She stood and looked at Mac for the next step. "Let's do some warmups and then you can show me what you can do."Mac was aware that she could execute the wrist lock and offered himself as the target. Jennifer performed the action three times in succession, the same way as she had in the bar and Mac assessed every detail before offering critique. "Your instincts are good but you form needs work. Your

balance is better than your form, which means the form is fixable. Did the self-defense instructor demonstrate the counter move an opponent would likely make?""There's a counter move?""There's always a counter move," Mac chuckled. "You might've gotten lucky the other night. Had that clown known how to get out of your hold, things could've gotten dangerous."Jennifer shrugged. "You were there. I wasn't worried and figured you'd do the whole damsel in distress routine if things got out of control.""But I won't always be there, as much as I am subscribed to the damsel in distress routine," Mac stressed. "You need to know the offensive move as well as the defensive, both sides of the same coin.""Okay, if I do the wrist lock again will you show me the countermove?""I will but it's going to involve me touching you, nowhere untoward, and you're going to land on the mat." Jennifer agreed to the terms and found herself getting really acquainted with the mat. It truly was a good thing she had never used the technique with someone that knew more than she did. They worked for a full hour. Once Mac was satisfied that she was getting the idea of how the wrist lock could be exploited, Mac showed her Horse Stance and ran down the basic blocks and kicks, one by one, and then together in a simple kata. He was glad to see she knew how to form a punch, showed her how to start with her hands at the waist and had her perform her punching technique high, middle, low. She had good rhythm. Mac ended the class as they had began. Jennifer put her hands on her sternum and controlled her breathing. *I am still. I can hear my-*The rattle of the lift drew Jennifer's attention and she lost the moment. "Well, look who it is bright and early," Richie announced. "You're the new cleaning crew?""We're in the middle of something, Richie," Mac sighed. Richie checked his watch, nodded and slipped away into his office. "Let's do that again."Jennifer closed her eyes again, took a breath and placed her hands, centered herself. *I am still. I can hear my heartbeat.*Mac ended the lesson teaching her how to bow out. "If you have a few minutes Richie has some paperwork in the office for you."Jennifer knocked on the office door. It was open, but manners were manners. "Hey Richie, Mac said you had some paperwork for me."Richie began shuffling mail, file folders and an assortment of papers until he found the ones he needed. "Just basic information we ask students or their parents to fill out," he announced before

handing her the new student packet. Jennifer took a pen out of her bag and started filling out the paperwork. “How did the lesson go?”“Good, really good. I know more now than I did before I came in,” she answered. “Mind if I sit down?”“Not at all, make yourself at home.” Home. Jennifer questioned if Richie lived in the same building referencing the lift. “My apologies on that. Mac told me he had a private student this morning and would be finished at nine.”“What time is it now?” Jennifer was surprised to hear it was nearing ten. “I guess time really does fly when you’re having fun.”Richie nodded and smiled along with her. “Oh, to your question, I don’t live here, Mac does. His loft is on the top floor. My place is near the court house.”Jennifer looked up and tried to picture where that was on the city map that had been slowly filling in since her arrival. She couldn’t picture it until Richie provided some landmarks. “So, am I going to be talking to you regarding cleaning or Mac?” “Probably both of us but for now I’d say the most important thing would be sweeping the floor and wiping down any equipment, if you have time today.”“I do have time today but my summer is winding down soon,” Jennifer sighed as she paused on the paperwork. “Gotta get it all in now before things get really crazy.”Richie grinned and leaned toward her. “We should go the skate park then. When are you available?”Jennifer swept the floor with the large broom with the light blue mop that lived in the corner in the back of the training area. The feel of the wood was noticeably different after sweeping it. When she was finished Jennifer put the broom back in its place, remembered to bow out of the dojo and slipped on her shoes."Same time next week," Mac said."Same time next week," she confirmed.

The Skate Park: Summer

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On Monday June 24th Jennifer was already at the skate park. Richie hadn't expected that. She had her board under her arm, a jacket on despite the warmth, a Marlboro going, and was looking at the bowl with a fixed expression. Jennifer was calculating something. He stopped at the top of the ramp. "You're early.""You're late."Richie looked at his watch. "Am I thought?" Richie countered. "Come on, let's shred."Jennifer was better than he'd expected. Not better than him but better than the bar had suggested. At Joe's Jennifer operated as someone careful, considered and economical. The skate park suggested someone who had made her peace with falling a long time ago and had built her whole game around that philosophy. She ate it on the third run. A clean wipeout, nothing dramatic, the board going one way and her body going the other. Jennifer rolled and came up looking at where the board had gone. Richie was beside her before he'd thought about it. Jennifer insisted that she was fine before he could say anything. "I know, you tucked the roll." And after a brief pause. "Where'd you learn that?""Seattle. Concrete there is unforgiving.""Tell me about it," Richie commented as he offered a hand up and handed her the board. They took a break on the concrete edge with water bottles in hand. "You are really good at this," Jennifer announced. It wasn't a compliment exactly, more like a notation."So are you," Richie returned."I'm decent. You're good."Richie looked at his board and turned it in his hands. "I've been doing it a long time.""How long?""A really long, long time."Jennifer understood that they were stumbling over an edge and didn't push. "I started at thirteen, Capitol Hill, self-taught.""It shows," Richie comment and then caught her look. "That's a compliment. Self-taught means you read the surface. Coached skaters sometimes miss that."Jennifer considered his assessment. "It's the drum thing."Richie was confused until she started air drumming. "You play drums. Of course you do.""Reading in advance," she said. "Committing before you have the whole picture. It's basically the same thing."He looked at her. She noted that his eyes were moving quickly. Something she said had landed. "Yeah," he said slowly. "Yeah, that's exactly what it is."Walking out of the park, Jennifer fell into step beside Richie without discussing it. His board under his arm. Hers under hers. At the entrance she stopped. "I need to get moving. My shift starts within the hour.""I can drop you," Richie

offered. She looked at the motorcycle and at him with the specific assessment of someone running the logistics. “The boards,” she argued. Richie thought about it for approximately two seconds. He went to the bike, opened the saddlebag, pulled out a bungee cord and looked at the two boards before smiling back at Jennifer. “This is going to work.”“Is it?” “Probably.”It worked. Barely. The boards were bungeed to the back with the specific precariousness of something held together by optimism and exactly one bungee cord. Jennifer looked at the arrangement for a moment. “If those fall off-““They won’t.”“If they-““They won’t,” Richie insisted before handing her his helmet and issuing an order. “Get on.”She got on. Jennifer had ridden on motorcycles before, but not often. The city moved past quickly. Being behind someone on a bike was different from every other kind of close in the world. Jennifer put her hands at his waist, not tight, just there. He didn’t say anything. Neither did she. Joe’s came up in seven minutes. Richie pulled to the curb, Jennifer got off the bike and removed the helmet. Richie unhooked the boards — both intact, bungee cord still holding — and handed hers over. Jennifer took it and returned the helmet. She looked at him.“Same time next week. Put it in your schedule,” Richie announced. Casual, like it was already decided. Jennifer looked at him sideways. “Bold and efficient.” Richie almost smiled and she almost smiled back at him. “Same time next week.”Jennifer went inside. Richie sat at the curb for a moment longer than he needed to before pulling away. He thought about the tucked roll for the rest of the afternoon. Richie also thought about how correct her hands felt at his waist. Both things, in no particular order. Inside, Methos was at his stool. He had been at his stool for the last twenty minutes. Jennifer came in, board under her arm and went straight behind the bar. Methos said nothing. She tied on her apron and checked the speed rack. She did not look at him. He waited.“Not a damn word,” Jennifer managed after a minute turned into five.“I didn’t say anything.”“Your face was involved in a three way conversation.”“Interesting turn of phrase, Marsh.” Methos picked up his beer. “I’m simply sitting here. As I often do.”Jennifer moved down the bar. Methos took a sip and slowly set the glass down like it was a gavel. Case closed. He waited until Jennifer came back his way. “You know, the motorcycle is a courtship display.” She glared at him. “Across most of

recorded human history, the offer of transportation has been a reliable indicator of romantic intent. The horse. The carriage. The—""Methos.""I'm providing context. It's what I do.""I needed a ride to work, he had a motorcycle. End of story."Methos sat for a moment. "Where were you with Richie that you needed a ride to get here?""We were at the skate park," Jennifer answered giving the cross streets of that area."So a date.""Two people who like to skateboard were skateboarding.""Was this prearranged? Did you two discuss these plans beforehand or was it a happy accident?" Jennifer told him the discussion had started at the dojo and they had looked at their calendars to find a time."So a date." Jennifer said nothing. She wanted it to count as a date but wasn't sure if Richie had felt the same. "Richie has two legs and could have walked you here. He chose the motorcycle and offered it to you. He also bungeed two skateboards to the back of it, which suggests either optimism or a desire to impress. I suspect both."She looked at him with the flat voice fully deployed. "You watched the whole thing," she sighed. "Why were you looking out the windows?"I just happened to be walking by when I heard the roar of metal thunder." Methos was unconvincing as someone who just happened to ever be doing anything. "The bungee cord was a bold choice. I'll give him that."*Well at least his damn feet weren't on the bar this time.*"How many people have a key to this place?" Jennifer demanded. It wasn't a real question. Methos finished his beer and ordered another. Nothing more was said about the matter of the motorcycle. Jennifer moved through the early shift thinking the issue had been put to bed. Mac entered with greetings, sat down and a Scotch was served without asking. Methos waited thirty seconds. "She arrived on Richie's motorcycle." Mac looked up at Jennifer briefly and then put his gaze on Methos. "They bungeed the skateboards to the back. Both of them. One cord." *Now would really be a good time for that damsel in distress thing.*"Methos, it was a ride." "It was a date.""Maybe it was, maybe it wasn't. Leave it alone."Methos didn't know how to leave anything alone. "Marsh and Ryan are dating.""We'll let you know when to hire the band and rent the hall, Methos," Mac grumbled."I'm simply reporting, Methos says. "You know how I feel about accurate-documentation."Mac picked up his Scotch and quietly revised his understanding of a situation he had already been watching closely. The FinchThe

call came through the Watcher network at half past four, routed through two field contacts and landing on Joe's phone while he was pulling a draft at the far end of the bar. He set the glass down. Read the message twice. Devon. En route Seacouver. Asking about the anomaly. ETA nightfall. He didn't write back. He picked up the phone and called Mac. Mac was already moving when Methos arrived at the loft. He'd been before anyone contacted Joe called. Methos had felt Devon come into the city, felt the shape of him, old and sharp and pointed in a direction Mac didn't like. Methos dropped his coat over the back of a chair and looked at him. "The anomaly," he said. It wasn't a question but it was an awful term for Jennifer."He's asking around the waterfront." Mac was checking the katana with the particular focus that meant he had already concluded how the situation would end. "Joe's description says cultivated. Old." "Devon of Exeter." Methos announced flatly. "Norman stock. Twelve hundred years, give or take. He collects oddities the way other men collect debts." He paused. "Clever enough to come quietly. Dangerous enough that quiet is all the warning you get." Mac looked at him. "I knew him," Methos said. "Once. Briefly." He picked up his coat again. "I'll come with you." Devon was standing near the water when they found him. He was exactly as Methos remembered; tall, unhurried, wearing his twelve centuries the way some men wore good wool. Devon turned when they approached. He had felt them both at a considerable distance and had simply chosen to wait. page1image28479344.png ¬ page1image28479344.png ¬"MacLeod," he said. Then, with slightly different inflection: "Adam." "Devon." Methos's voice gave nothing. "It's been a long time."“Everything is a long time, eventually." Devon's gaze moved between them with the practiced calm of a man too old to be hurried by most things. "I'm not here for either of you. I heard a rumor about a finch. Small thing, new, completely unreadable. I came to see for myself." Mac was very still. Methos had spent years reading the stillness of dangerous men, and the quality of Mac's posture indicated that he was not there to negotiate."A finch named Marsh," Devon continued pleasantly. "Apparently she has no idea what she is. I find that interesting." He tilted his head. "You know her." "She is not yours to find interesting," Mac said. His voice was level. That was somehow worse than if it hadn't been. "You will leave Seacouver

tonight, take word back to whoever told you there was anything to find that there isn't and that will be the end of it." Devon studied him. "You're very certain of that." "Yes, I am," Mac said simply. Something shifted in Devon's expression — a calculation completing, a conclusion reached. He smiled, faintly, the way a man smiles when he has decided that the interesting answer is the dangerous one. "I think," he said, "I'd like to see her for myself." Mac drew the katana. Joe was behind the bar when the lights went out. Not a flicker — a clean, absolute cessation, the music stopping mid-note, the street outside going dark all the way to the corner. The handful of early customers made the usual noises of surprise. Joe gripped the bar top and did not make any noise at all. Jennifer was already moving. She'd been running glasses from the back when it happened. She came through the door with them still in her hands, assessed the room in one sweep, set the glasses down and said, "Okay, candles are under the bar, back shelf, box on the left." "I know where the candles are," Joe said. "It's my bar. I put them there." "Then let's get them lit." Jennifer headed back through to the storage room, and he could hear her pulling open the supply closet. Joe stood very still in the dark bar and sighed. *There it is. That's done.* He got the candles out. They were halfway through lighting the bar when the door opened and Methos entered. Jennifer looked up from the table she was working and clocked him immediately. Joe had noticed she had great door-awareness, some reflex she probably didn't know she had, and something in her expression shifted slightly. Methos was not behaving normally. Methos had come in fast, which wasn't his way, and he had stopped just inside the door. He looked at Joe with a mixed expression and did not sit down. Methos stood there with his coat, hands loose at his sides and full on alertness. Joe gave him the smallest nod and Methos's shoulders dropped one degree. "Power's out," Jennifer said, watching him. "I noticed." He didn't look at her. Then, like a correction, he did. "You all right?" "I work in a bar," she said. "I know where the candles are." He almost smiled at that. Almost. He still didn't sit down.]Joe watched Methos breathe. Mac came in ten minutes later. Jennifer was behind the bar running on the low amber light of a dozen candles. When she saw him her face settled. He was solid, present and his coat was damp at the shoulders from the air off of the water.

page1image28479344.png ¬Mac met Joe's eyes across the bar. Joe gave him a small nod and something in him went quiet. Methos straightened off the wall the moment Mac stepped fully inside. He came to Mac in two strides and they spoke in low voices by the door. It was more like a transfer of information than a conversation. Mac nodded once, short, definitive. Methos picked up his coat. He looked at Jennifer. "I'll be back," he said. "Watch your head on the door," she said without looking up. He was gone. The bar went on in candlelight. Joe poured. Mac settled at the end of the bar and accepted a drink he didn't really need. The three of them existed in the warm unsteady amber and didn't talk about anything in particular. Jennifer moved around the space relighting the things that kept guttering. The power did not return and time passed. Then Jennifer came back behind the bar, set down the lighter, and looked at both of them. She was not accusatory nor frightened. Her voice was quiet and level."I've experienced power outages before," Jennifer announced. "That was not a regular power outage." Mac looked at her. She waited. She was good at waiting. Jennifer made the silence do the work and let it sit there until it filled the space between them entirely. "No, it wasn't." Jennifer didn't react to being confirmed. She'd already known. She was asking about the rest of it. "Is everyone okay?" "Yes." She held his gaze for a moment like she was checking the reading on an old instrument, nodded once and started wiping down the bar. "Okay." Jennifer didn't push further. Joe looked at Mac over her head. His face said nothing but eyes did all the talking. Outside, the street lights began to come back on one at a time, and inside the bar the candles threw long warm shadows and the evening went on. Mac stayed until closing. He wasn't about to let Jennifer walk home alone, not that night. When Joe had locked the door and gone to count the till, Jennifer leaned on the bar across from him with coffee in hand and looked at him for a moment. "You ever see Cinema Paradiso?" Mac indicated he had watched it several times. "Alfredo, the projectionist, he knows the whole time. He knows exactly what Salvatore is and what he's going to be and what he needs." Jennifer took a sip of her coffee. "And he never says it directly. He just — tends to it. From the side. Without making it a thing."Mac said nothing. "And Salvatore figures it out, eventually, in his own time." She focused on Mac. "That's a good way to do it.""It's a good

film," Mac said carefully meeting her eyes head on.'"It's a great film, one of the best," Jennifer said lifting her mug in salute to movie magic. "I'm not pushing. I just want you to know that I know there's something to push upon."Mac looked at her for a long moment. "Noted."Mac gave her a ride home. He watched her go up the steps with her bag and her board and not once looking back. He sat at the curb for a moment after the building door closed. He thought about Alfredo, about the reel of film. The kisses cut out one by one over thirty years, saved up, given back at the end when there was nothing left to protect the boy from. The love that expressed itself entirely in what it arranged and never in what it said. Mac had done that. He had done versions of that across four hundred years, the ones he'd loved well and sent forward into their lives, into their futures, away from him because away from him was where the future was. He looked at the door she'd gone through. Jennifer was not going to be one of those people.

Sunday Funday

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It was a Sunday Funday and Jennifer was meeting up with Richie at the skate park for their second session. Her legs and shoulders were still sore from training with Mac and she hoped a few Ollies would help and not worsen her muscular-skeletal system. Jennifer was in the shallow bowl, working on a line she'd been trying since she was sixteen, when Richie arrived. She heard his motorcycle roar to the curb before he announced himself. "Excuse me, do you have a moment to talk about our lord and savior Tony Hawk?" Richie greeted with a grin. He was glad she had showed. "I'm familiar with the text." "I'd love to get a look at your footnotes later," Richie returned just delighted with the exchange. Richie

dropped into the bowl behind her. Her thigh muscles started doing the twitchy thing again. She sat down and Richie joined her. “That reminds me, I wanted to ask you about Mac. I went to the dojo yesterday afternoon because I’m a glutton for punishment and he threw me around without breaking a sweat of his own. My legs are trembling and my shoulders are killing me.” “I’m not sure I heard a question.” Jennifer asked how Mac managed to have so much vitality for a man of his age. Richie held it together the best he could. “Well, he’s pretty serious about nutrition and physical fitness. He’ll probably juice up some vegetables for you if you ask nicely.” “So, clean living then?” Richie nodded. “Hardly ever eats junk food, works out a lot, smokes a cigar every once in a blue moon. It’s either that or those strong Scottish genes of his.” Jennifer raised her eyebrows. “Oh, he really is from Scotland. By the sound of that accent he must’ve immigrated recently.” The conversation had taken a turn Richie did not want to encourage. “Ready? Let’s session.” They skated for another hour before Jennifer abruptly stepped off her board. “I can feel my nervous system making a very poor decision.” Richie rolled up beside her, easy. “We can call it.” Jennifer watched as Richie rooted through his pack-spare wheels, tools, a hoodie and a fruit punch Gatorade that wasn’t chilled but would do the job. “Feed your cells and then we’ll get you home.” She unscrewed the plastic cap and started guzzling the electrolytes. Jennifer silently watched from the sidewalk as Richie tidied up a few details. He performed the standard kick flip on his deck and strapped it to his pack. He then picked hers up by the truck and tucked it under his arm. Jennifer finished the entire 32 ounce bottle before Richie started rigging their gear to the bike with the bungee cord that had not failed him. “That’s never happened to me before.” “That’s never happened to you after training for hours with Mac before,” Richie corrected. “What did he have you doing anyway?” Jennifer recounted the horse stance, the kicks, the blocks, the punches, the kata and the way she almost took a punch to the ribs because she didn’t have her hands up. “Are these activities not going to be compatible, because I will tell you right now that lessons with Mac is not my priority in this situation.” “You can grind and practice martial arts with Mac. It’s just going to take a little time,” Richie announced before detailing his diagnosis stopping time to time using his body as a visual aid.

“Okay so you spent a lot of time yesterday in a bent knee stance on a solid wood floor and probably built up some muscle memory. But when you’re skating you’re on a surface with a lateral movement.” Jennifer continued working the thought. “So, my body was so hyped up with horse stance that my legs thought they were in the dojo when I actually needed them out here feeling the wobble.” “Feeling the wobble. Exactly,” Richie responded. “Most people just fall down.” “I didn’t fall,” Jennifer sighed. “You didn’t fall,” Richie confirmed before handing her a helmet. He had been riding with two ever since their first trip to the skate park. Jennifer put on the helmet, climbed on behind him and placed her hands at his waist. “Ready?” “Where?” “Anywhere you’d like.” Ice cream turned out to be the correct answer.

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Mac was quiet for a moment. He wasn’t reading Jennifer’s stance. Mac examining something smaller than that. The way her weight settled, the way her hands came to rest, and the speed bag rhythm Jennifer did behind the bar without knowing she was doing it. No watch on her left wrist which meant nothing by itself. He almost smiled. One corner, just the one. "I can't believe it," he said, and the tone was different — lighter, a tease, the specific warmth of someone who has just caught something. “You've been hiding something from me." Jennifer insisted that she had not been intentionally hiding anything from him. “You're left handed," Mac announced. “I can write with both," she said. "Always could. Ask anyone." "I'm not asking anyone," he replied. "I'm telling you." "I'm ambidextrous," Jennifer insisted "Genuinely." "No one is one hundred percent ambidextrous," Mac insisted. "Even a single ounce of torque in one direction, that's your dominant side. You can be only one." He looked at her. "You're left handed and you've been compensating so naturally for so long that you stopped noticing." “All right, let’s say I am, how does that change anything?” "We're going to work on your right side," he said. "Not because it's weak. Because when you lead with your left you've been telegraphing it your entire life and you don't know it." He paused. "We're going to make them even. That left hand is gong to be one of your secret

weapons."

The Descendants Evening

Chapter 4 The Descendents EveningJuly 8 - 3rd Skate Park It was the third occasion that Richie and Jennifer met up at the skate park. She brought Gatorade as the previous outing had ended with her sitting on the edge of the bowl feeling the consequences of two hours of skating in summer heat without hydrating. It was a rookie mistake and she was not a rookie, she had just forgotten. Jennifer was drinking it at the top of the bowl when Richie dropped in beside her, board under his arm, slightly out of breath from the line he'd been working on the far side of the park. He looked at the Gatorade. "Orange.""Obviously."Richie sat down. He looked out at the park. There were a few kids on the flat ground. "In my experience," Richie announced with the tone of someone opening something carefully, "most skaters that drum have very strong opinions about the Descendants."She stared at him briefly. "I think that's a very leading question," Jennifer replied just as carefully. Richie smiled. She caught it in her peripheral vision, the quick bright smile, the unguarded one. "It's not a question. It's an observation.""It's an observation designed to provoke a specific response," Jennifer returned. "Which makes it a leading question wearing an observation's clothes.""Okay." Richie stood and stretched his legs. "Do you have opinions about the Descendents?""That's a question.""That's a straight question," he said. "No leading. Just asking."Jennifer drank her Gatorade. "Milo Goes to College."Richie acknowledged that Jennifer's answer was going to require his full attention. "Yeah," he said slowly."1982," Jennifer continued, "Fourteen songs, twenty-seven minutes. They understood something

about economy that most bands spend their whole career trying to figure out and don't." "Okay but I Don't Want to Grow Up—""Is a perfect song," she said. "I'm not arguing that.""You say that like you're about to argue something else.""I'm going to argue," she said, "that Milo is the document and everything after is the commentary. Which is not nothing, the commentary is good. But the document is the document.""All is literally called All," Richie stated. "Like they named it that on purpose. Like they knew.""They knew they were making a very good album," she agreed before offering her counterargument. "They didn't know they were making Milo. Nobody knows when they're making Milo. That's what makes it Milo.""That's circular.""It's accurate."Richie pushed off the ground with his heel, rocking slightly. He was thinking. She could see him thinking. His quick eyes working through it."The drums on Milo," he said."Bill Stevenson," she said. "Yes.""He was seventeen.""I know how old he was.""Seventeen," Richie said again, with the emphasis of someone for whom that number had a unique texture. "And he played like that."Jennifer noted there was something new in his tone. It wasn't wistful exactly, something more specific than that. The particular quality she'd been cataloguing, the not-quite-rightness of his relationship with time. Seventeen landing differently for Richie Ryan than it did for anyone else in the skate park. She let it sit. She didn't push it."He played like that," she agreed. They skated for another hour. The argument continued between runs. Jennifer took the position that the early catalog was the peak. Richie suggested assigning so much weight to the early catalog was the kind of thing people said about bands they'd loved young and were protecting. It was not analysis, it was nostalgia. Jennifer stated there was nothing wrong with nostalgia when the object of it had genuinely earned it. Richie stated that her response was the most dignified defense of nostalgia he'd ever heard. Jennifer thanked him and he laughed. The sun was just beginning to set when they picked up their boards. The StairsJennifer lived eight blocks from the park, about a mile, and she hadn't mentioned it. Richie fell into step beside her in the natural way of someone who wasn't ready for the conversation to end and wasn't going to make anything of it. She didn't make anything of it either. They walked. The argument evolved from the Descendants to Black Flag to the question of whether the

DC scene and the California scene were in genuine dialogue or parallel development. Jennifer had opinions about that topic and Richie had different view. Neither of them was entirely wrong."You've got the Bad Brains record," he said. Not a question."I've got the Bad Brains record," she confirmed."The original cassette or—""Vinyl," she said. "1982 pressing. I paid too much for it and I would do it again.""Where did you find a 1982 pressing?""Estate sale in Tacoma. The guy who died had excellent taste and his kids did not know what they had.""That's—" He stopped. "That's incredible.""It is," Jennifer agreed. "I felt briefly terrible about it and then I put it on and I felt fine."Richie laughed openly and unguarded. They arrived at her building. They both stopped on the sidewalk feeling the beat of an evening ending that hadn't entirely decided if it wanted to end."The 1982 pressing," Richie said. "Of the Bad Brains record.""That's the one we were discussing.""Sometime," he said. "If you wanted. I'd like to hear it." Not can I come up, not pushing anything. Just sometime, if she wanted."Sometime," Jennifer agreed. The confirmation settled in him, briefly and visibly. "Okay," he said. "Good." Richie stood there for one more moment, not awkward just present. Richie picked up his board. "Milo though.""Milo," she affirmed."We're not done with this.""We're not done with this at all."Richie pushed off down the sidewalk. Third FloorJennifer reached the door of her building and her left quad informed her, with no ambiguity, that it was done. Not cramping, not sore in the ordinary way, just done. The muscle that had been working for two hours had used up everything it had and was filing a formal complaint. She kept her face neutral. She had a lot of practice keeping her face neutral, but her voice was anything but. Jennifer let off a string of expletives that could have made a trucker blush. Richie was back in no time, up the stairs and ready to help. "Which one is yours?""Third floor," Jennifer announced. "Cool," Richie said. Just that, no performance. Jennifer got the front door open. She went up the first flight at a pace she was controlling very carefully, with her hand on the railing gripping it. Richie was behind her. He didn't comment or crowd her, but he read a surface before he committed to it. At that moment the surface was Jennifer. Richie was reading her and he was staying exactly where he was. Jennifer got to the first landing and paused under the pretense of adjusting her bag.

Her left quad said nothing because it was beyond communication. It was a full on labor strike. Jennifer went up the second flight. Her right knee locked on the fourteenth step and just stopped cooperating. She caught herself on the railing, one hand landing hard. Jennifer kept moving because stopping would have been worse. She made it to the second landing and stood there for a moment with both hands on the rail. Her breathing was even and deliberate. Richie stopped beside her. He did not ask if she was okay or make it a production. "Third floor's stupid," she groaned."Little bit," Richie replied."Building's from 1947.""I can tell."Jennifer looked at the next flight of stairs and took inventory of her legs. "Give it a second," Richie said. Quietly. Not a question, not a suggestion, just information. Jennifer gave it a second. "The trick," he said, conversationally, like they were still talking about music, "is to keep the weight forward on the next flight. Heel pressure makes it worse. I've skated for a long time.I know what locked quads do on stairs."She looked at him for an additional moment. "Forward weight," she said."Forward weight."Jennifer ascended the third flight with her weight forward. It was not fine but it was manageable, which was what she needed it to be. She arrived at her door, got the key in the lock on the first and chose to count as a win. The ApartmentRichie assessed Jennifer's apartment as functional. She had been there two months and still had a few boxes that needed attention. The highlights he decided were the coffee maker, the turntable and the records. The turntable was level and correct. The records were in two crates beside it; organized, not alphabetically, in the particular order that made sense to her and would make sense to anyone who understood what they were looking at. The Bad Brains record was in the second crate, third from the front, next to the Minutemen and ahead of X. Richie walked in and crouched down in front of the crates. Jennifer let him look. She went to the kitchen and put the kettle on because her legs needed her to stand still for a minute. The kettle gave her a reason. Jennifer heard him going through the second crate carefully. It was the sound of someone who knew how to handle vinyl. He did not pull but tilted reading spines. "You've got the Minutemen," Richie announced."Double Nickels. Yes.""And X.""Los Angeles and Wild Gift."A pause."Wild Gift," he said, with the tone of someone confirming something important."Wild Gift," she

returned. Another pause. Jennifer heard him move to the first crate. “You’ve got the Replacements,” he said.“Let It Be and Tim.”“Tim—”“Is where they figured out how to be enormous without losing the plot,” she said. “Yes. I know.”Richie chuckled. It was the best discussion on music he had ever experienced. Jennifer heard him settle, sitting on the floor with the ease of someone who had decided this was where he was going to be. She made coffee. Her legs were reporting in at a grudging forty percent functionality, which was enough. She brought two mugs out and set his on the floor beside him. Jennifer was glad she had taken sugar packets and individual creamers from Joe’s when she had. It had been a hopeful, small crime that no jury would convict. Richie had the Bad Brains record in his hands. Carefully. Correctly. He looked at it for a long moment — the cover, the label, the pressing date. “1982.”“1982.”He turned it over, looked at the track listing and then at Jennifer. “Can I?” She gestured at the turntable. Richie stood and put the record on with reverence. The needle found the groove. Pay to Cum came out of the speakers and filled the apartment; the compressed fury, the opening thirty seconds of declaration. Richie sat back down on the floor next to Jennifer. They listened. The coffee was good. Her legs were slowly negotiating a settlement with the rest of her body.A VarietyAfter the third track she said, “Mac trains you, right?” Before she could continue her stomach made a sound that was not ambiguous or ignorable. Richie looked at her with a smirk. “When did you last eat?”“Today, earlier.” “Specifically.”She thought about it: coffee at six before her shift, the half sandwich at the bar that she’d eaten standing up between customers. “I had a sandwich.”“Half a sandwich. I saw you. I came in for coffee. You were eating half a sandwich while simultaneously making change and telling someone the kitchen was closed.” Richie paused. “You ate the half and then you put the other half back in the wrapper and I watched you not go back to it for the rest of the shift.”Jennifer looked at him for a moment. “You’re observant.”“You’re not subtle when you’re hungry,” Richie stated as he rose to his feet. “What have you got?”“Coffee,” she said. “I have coffee. And—” she did the mental inventory, “—I think there’s peanut butter.”“Do you have bread?”A pause. “There’s crackers,” Jennifer sighed. Those might have been taken from a restaurant as well, maybe from Joe’s.“Mind if I take a look?” Jennifer ap-

proved the request forgetting she had an armada in the refrigerator. “What is going on in here? There’s a lime and a blue super ball.”Jennifer couldn’t help but smile. “Oh, that’s Admiral Stowie and his crew.”“Small crew,” Richie commented. “Did they lose all the food that should be in your refrigerator to some arctic force in the freezer?”She couldn’t top that as the maritime history of Admiral Stowie. “Last time I went shopping a lime got in my bag. I didn’t buy it, it was a stow-away, and I put him in charge of the refrigerator.”“And the blue ball still in the plastic covering?”“Part of the crew. The plastic is his armor.”Richie nodded. It was a very plausible story, one that amused him and favored his view of her whole personality. “Do you have a phone book?”“It’s 1991, yes I have a phone book.”“There’s a place,” he said. “On Clement. Russo’s. You know it?”“I’ve only been here two months.”“I’m calling Russo’s.”“Richie—”“I’ve got it,” he said. Simply, stating a fact. He had it. That was all. Richie found the phone book where phone books lived, in the second drawer, always. He called Russo’s from her kitchen phone. Jennifer listened to him order with confidence. “The Margherita with the extra basil. And the arancini if Angelo’s still there. Tell him it’s Richie.” Another pause, and then something shifted in his face — warm, genuine, the real smile. “Yeah, send a variety, one of each.” He gave her address and hung up. Richie came back and sat on the floor. “Angelo makes the arancini himself,” he said. “If it’s not Angelo they’re fine. If it’s Angelo they’re—” he paused, looking for the word.“Specific?”“Specific,” he agreed. “The good specific.”“How do you know a pizza place on Clement that well.” “I’ve lived in Seacouver a while.”“How long?”Richie picked up his coffee mug, remembered it was empty and put it down. “A few years. On and off.”“On and off,” Jennifer echoed.“I travel a bit but always come back.” She looked at him. They way he had said that he always came back meant something larger than the words. “Put something on,” he urged nodding at the turntable. Double Nickels on the Dime because it was long enough to cover the wait and the Minutemen had opinions about themselves that Jennifer respected. Richie made a sound of approval. DeSalvo’sAfter the third track Jennifer returned to her earlier topic. “Mac trains you,” she stated and Richie affirmed that was true. “What does that look like?” “Early mornings, mostly, before we open the dojo. And we do everything: hand to hand,

how to read someone before they move, how to fall correctly, which sounds boring and is actually the most important thing." Richie paused. "How to not be an idiot, which takes longer than the rest of it.""The falling thing," Jennifer groaned. "He spent forty minutes on that with me the first session."Richie nodded. "He told me about the arm lock.""Did he?" "Joe told me about the arm lock. Mac confirmed it when I asked him." He looked at her. "Mac doesn't confirm things he doesn't think are worth confirming."She was quiet for a moment. "It wasn't that impressive.""Mac offered to teach you," Richie said. Simply. Like that was the whole argument, which it was. "Mac doesn't offer that to just anyone."She looked at him. "He offered it to you.""Mac didn't offer it to me. Mac caught me breaking into his shop and made a decision. That's completely different." Richie announced with conviction. "He's never just offered that to someone who didn't already know about—" he stopped. Jennifer waited. Richie redirected, smoothly enough that she clocked it. "To someone new."She filed it and let it go. "The falling thing is harder than it looks.""It's always harder than it looks," Richie commented with emphasis on the word always. "You get it though. Once you get it you can't not see it and how much of everything else depends on it.""It's the drum thing again," she said. "The preparation is earlier than the moment.""Yes. Exactly.""Does he mop the floor with you?"Richie laughed reflecting on his collection of memories of training with Mac. "At the beginning he wasn't even trying and I couldn't touch him. I'd come at him and he'd just—" the small redirecting gesture with his hand, barely anything "—and I'd be somewhere else. Not a big move. Just economy. Like he'd done it so many times that all the extra had been taken out.""He did that to me in the first session," she said. "I came at him, he was showing me something, and I moved wrong. I tried to correct it and he just—" she made the same gesture, unconsciously mirroring Richie's, "—and I was on the mat looking at the ceiling.""What did you do?""I laid there for a second," she answered. "Then I got up and asked him to show me what he did."Richie looked at her. His face settled into warmth and certainty. He read on Jennifer had just been confirmed in a way that felt good. "What did he say""He showed me, slowly, three times. Then he made me try it.""Did you get it?""Not the first time, but by the third time I got the

shape of it."Richie nodded. He knew the process from the inside. "He's got a lot of experience with the physical stuff. All of it. More than a dojo would account for." Richie was quiet and Jennifer continued, "He moves like someone who's been doing it a very long time." She was not pushing, just accurately describing what she'd observed."Yeah," Richie said carefully. "He has.""How long?""A long time." She looked at him and found Richie looking back with the steady directness of someone who had said exactly as much as he was prepared to say. Then the buzzer went. Saved by the bell. Richie was up before she'd finished processing the sound, faster always, the easy speed of someone comfortable in their body, and he hit the intercom."Third floor," he said. Audible footsteps tapped on the stairs. "I wasn't sure what you'd want to drink. I didn't know if you were a Diet Coke person or—" "I'm a coffee person," she said."I got a variety," he said. "No self-respecting person drinks coffee with pizza."Jennifer opened the door. Angelo was on the landing with the pizza box, the arancini bag and a paper sack that clinked. He handed over the pizza and the arancini. He reached into the paper sack and produced, with the air of a man completing a delivery manifest: one two-liter of Diet Coke, one two-liter of regular Coke, a bottle of Orangina and a small bottle of San Pellegrino."Riccardo," Angelo said, in the tone of a man who had made this delivery and was withholding comment."Angelo," Richie said. "You made the arancini.""Certo." He looked at Jennifer. "Mangia," he said, like an instruction."Grazie," she said. He looked at her with new interest and smiled at Richie. "Brava," Angelo announced before he departed. Jennifer looked at the two two-liters, the Orangina, and the San Pellegrino. "You bought four drinks.""A variety," he said. "I didn't know your whole situation.""What situation?""Some people are Diet Coke people," he announced. "Some people are regular Coke people. Some people think soda is poison and want the sparkling water but won't ask for it. Some people—""What's the Orangina for?""The Orangina is for a person who thinks American soda is too sweet but won't say so because it seems pretentious.""Are you a person who thinks American soda is too sweet?""Sometimes."Jennifer picked up the Orangina, looked it over and put it on the counter."Okay, what do we have for cups?"Jennifer opened the cabinet revealing six mugs, four new that matched, one pint

glass from a bar she'd worked at in Portland and one mug that said Seattle on it that her cousin had given her as a joke. "Mugs or just drink from the bottle?""We're sitting on your floor," Richie said. "I can just drink from the bottle.""Okay." She put one of the mugs back. "Plates or just the box?""Just the box," he said, without hesitation."Napkins," she said. "I have —" she checked. "I have paper towels.""Paper towels are napkins," Richie said."They are," Jennifer agreed. She tore off two lengths of paper towel, handed him one and they sat down on the floor with the pizza box open between them and the arancini beside it. The Orangina and a Diet Coke were within reach. The pizza had game. Every component was correct in the way of something made by someone who cared about getting it right. The basil was fresh. The crust had the char of a very hot oven and someone who knew when to pull it."This is very good," she said."I know."They ate. Jennifer took the Diet Coke and Richie took the Orangina, which she did not comment on. The arancini were Angelo's. Jennifer understood this immediately, the difference between a thing that was fine and a thing that someone had made with the full weight of their attention. She ate one and closed her eyes briefly."Yeah," Richie said, watching her face. What he saw was pure pleasure."Yeah," she said as she opened her eyes and grinned at him. "How did Angelo end up on Clement?" "He came over in the sixties. His brother had a place and then retired. Angelo didn't." He picked up an arancini. "He's been there since '68.""You know the whole story," she commented."Angelo talks," Richie said. "If you listen. He'll talk your ear off."And it rang true because Richie listened when people talked. Jennifer made a mental note to underline that fact in her journal before returning to her earlier examination."Mac has swords. I've seen the coat and there's a rack at DeSalvo's that really doesn't fit the DeSalvo's interior.""He has a strong interest," Richie said carefully, "in historical swordsmanship.""Historical swordsmanship.""It's a legitimate discipline," Richie said with the tone of someone who had deployed this sentence more than once."I didn't say it wasn't.""Mac has—" Richie stopped. Tried again. "He has a lot of experience with swords.""A lot of experience.""Significant, extensive. You could say—" he stopped again. The internal reckoning, brief and visible. She watched him hear what he was about to say approximately half a second before he said it.

"—the sword experience."A beat passed as there was a pause between tracks on the record. "The Sword Experience," she said, with the careful neutrality of a bartender who had heard everything and was choosing, in this specific instance, not to deploy any of it."It's—" Richie started."Richie," she said. "I'm not going to make anything of that. I'm going to fileit and move on."He looked at her. The quick eyes, reading her face for the angle, finding none. "Okay.""Mac has extensive sword experience. He runs events. He teaches it. He moves like someone who has been doing it since before either of us was born." She picked up her Diet Coke. "I've been tovDeSalvo's a few times and I already know not to ask the next question." Richie was quiet for a moment. "You're not going to push on it?""Not tonight." Not tonight, not not ever. He heard the distinction clearly because she intended him to. Richie acknowledged that Jennifer Marsh was going to get there entirely under her own power and there was nothing anyone could do about it except wait."He's the best teacher I've ever had," Richie said, after a moment. Quietly. Not a deflection, just the truth, offered in lieu of the things he couldn't say. "The things he knows, the way he knows them, it's not like anything else. You'll see if you keep going to DeSalvo's.""I plan to keep going," she said. He nodded like that was settled. Like he'd known. "Good.""Do you think Mac would teach me kendo, kendo specifically?" Jennifer questioned. "I've always been interested in it. Stage fighting, I did some theater tech in high school, I got to watch the fight choreography, the sword work. There's something about the formality of it. The way it's a whole discipline, not just technique."Richie was quiet for a moment. "Mac knows kendo.""I assumed.""He knows—" Richie stopped. "He knows a lot of sword disciplines, morethan a lot. If you asked him about kendo specifically he'd have—" another stop, the careful navigation, "context for it.""Context?""Informed opinions," Richie clarified. "About its development. Where it came from. How it's changed." He took a bit of pizza. "He'd probably have thoughts about the formalization of it. The way it became a discipline.""As opposed to what it was before it was formalized," Jennifer commented. Richie picked up his Orangina. He took a drink and looked at the turntable. "You could ask him," he said. "About kendo. He'd either say es or he'd say not yet.""Not yet meaning he'd want the foundation first."

“Meaning he’d want you to have the foundation first,” Richie agreed with a nod. “He’s got a sequence. He doesn’t always explain the sequence but it’s there. The falling thing is part of it.”“What else is part of it?” Jennifer questioned.“Distance,” he said. “How you understand the space between you and another person. Most people don’t think about it until someone’s already inside it.” He paused. “Mac always thinks about it. He’ll teach you to do the same.”She was quiet for a moment. “That’s already happening,” she said. “I noticed it at the bar, the distance thing.” She looked at her slice. “I noticed it before, I think. I just didn’t have language for it.”“The kendo thing, ask him. Seriously, he’ll appreciate that you know the word. That you came in with a specific interest and not just wanting to learn how to fight.”“I don’t want to learn to fight,” Jennifer argued.“I know,” he said. “That’s the point.” Jennifer looked at the Orangina and Richie drinking it with the ease of someone for whom this was just what you reached for. Not a choice, exactly. A habit. “Orangina. You drink it like it’s your default.”“You can get it here, obviously but it’s easier to find in—” “Europe,” she said.“Europe,” he confirmed. Jennifer ate her pizza. She let the silence do its work, which it did, because she had learned that silence was a more efficient tool than questions with Richie Ryan.“I was there for about a year,” he said. “On and off. After things, after Mac, after everything changed.” He rocked the Orangina bottle on the floor. “I needed to, I don’t know, go somewhere that wasn’t here. Figure out what the new version of things looked like.”“On your own.”“Mostly,” he said. “Mac was, he checked in, but yeah, mostly on my own.”She nodded. “What did you do?”“Things,” he said. And then, because she was looking at him with the patient flat expression, “Odd jobs, at first. I was good with my hands. Mechanical stuff.” He paused. “And then I found the racing.”She looked at him. A flicker lit up his face, there and gone. Something crossed Richie’s face that was not quite wistful, not quite loss and not quite pride. It was all three compressed into a single beat. His hands moved slightly on the Orangina bottle, adjusting the grip, remembering something physical. Something fast. Something that had required both hands and full attention and had mattered in a way he hadn’t entirely put down.“What kind?”“Motorcycles, road racing. Europe has, there are circuits, real ones. And then there’s the smaller stuff, the regional

stuff, the races that aren't on any official calendar." He looked at the turntable. "I was good at it.""More than good," she said. He looked at her. "You said it like that, 'I was good at it.' The way you say something when good isn't the right word but you're not going to use the right one."He was quiet for a moment. "Yeah, okay, more than good.""What happened?" The silence was different. Not the silence of someone deciding how much to give but the silence of someone standing in a place and choosing whether to stay there or not. Richie came back. "Things got complicated," he said. "The life, Mac's world, the stuff I'd gotten into. It doesn't really, you can't just have a racing career and also—" he stopped. He started again. "It was hard to stay in one place long enough. To commit to a full season." He turned the bottle. "And some of the people I was racing with started asking questions I couldn't answer.""About why you didn't get hurt the way other people got hurt," she said. Richie was still. "I've seen Mac at DeSalvo's, after a session that was harder than usual. He was fine when he shouldn't have been fine." She paused. "I filed it. I haven't pushed on it. I'm not pushing on it now. I'm just telling you what I've already clocked so you know where I am." A long moment. She picked up her Diet Coke. He picked up his Orangina. "Did you win," she said. "The racing?"The ghost of the real smile surfaced. "Sometimes.""More than sometimes."The smile grew slightly less ghostly. "Yeah, more than sometimes.""And you miss it." He thought about it, really thought about it. Richie didn't give reflexive answers to real questions. "The speed, yeah. The way everything gets narrow. When you're on a circuit at full speed the whole world goes down to the next corner and your hands and the bike, and nothing else exists." He paused. "I miss that.""The drum thing," Jennifer commented. "When it's right, everything goes narrow. The whole world is the next beat and your hands and nothing else exists."He looked at her for a long moment. "Yeah, exactly that."They sat with it, the understanding of two people who had each found a thing that made the world go small, manageable and present, and recognized it in each other."And what are you thinking about now?" Richie question. "Whether or not my past in motorcycle racing makes me a worse or better driver for you to co-ride with?"She was caught unprepared. "You know, I hadn't thought about that in the two minutes I've been aware of this fact. What is your

analysis?" Jennifer questioned recalling all of Methos's comments about the motorcycle being romantic transportation."I hope you'll come to have a confidence in me that makes the question seem ridiculous."The Minutemen played. The Orangina was mostly gone, two slices of pizza remained along with one arancini."You take it.""No, you take it and the rest of the pie," Richie replied. He had food in his apartment."Richie.""Jen."She looked at him. "Split the last one?" It was the correct decision. Angelo would have approved. The DoorstepJennifer yawned at the end of the seventh track. Not a small polite yawn, a full yawn, that reflected two hours of skating, three flights of stairs and the exhaustion of a body that had been sitting too long. She caught it late. Jennifer pressed the back of her hand against her mouth but the damage was done. Richie looked at her. She looked at him. "Don't.""I didn't say anything," Richie replied while shrugging his shoulders."You were about to."Richie gathered the empty bottles, put them by the door, and placed the remainder of the pizza on her counter. He did this with the naturalness of someone who wasn't performing tidiness; it just needed doing. He looked at the San Pellegrino, still sitting on the counter, untouched. "You want this?""I'm a coffee person."Richie took it and tucked it under his arm. He then picked up his board and shrugged on his jacket. Jennifer got up from the floor. Her legs reported in at a reasonably functional. They stood in the specific geography of her doorway. Jennifer had her hand on the open door and Richie was on the threshold. It was not a long moment nor was it a short moment. The energy in the air was cooking something, knew it and wasn't going to be rushed. Richie looked at Jennifer with the directness that was just how he was, present about things that mattered to him. And Jennifer was beginning to matter more to him every day. "See you on the flip side," Richie offered. Not a question, not quite a goodbye. Just the shape of the next thing, already there, already agreed. "See you on the flip side," Jennifer returned. Richie held her gaze for one more moment, nodded and took his leave. She stood in the doorway. He didn't look back. Jennifer watched him reach the stairs, found him to be completely unbothered by the gear under his arms. She watched him disappear around the landing, listened to his footsteps descend in an easy, unhurried, no-locked knees pace. She heard the building door and then nothing. She stood

there for a moment longer than she needed to and then stepped back into her apartment. She closed the door and leaned against it in the quiet. Jennifer examined the room and found the Bad Brains sleeve not quite flush. She looked at that last thing for a moment. Richie had left a musical bookmark. Jennifer put Milo Goes to College on because it was late and her legs were tired. Sometimes all that was needed was twenty-seven minutes of something that didn't apologize for itself. She sat on the floor and thought about narrow worlds, fast things and the specific shape of a person who listened when people talked. Jennifer considered that the word sometimes meant more than sometimes implied. Jennifer thought about DeSalvo's, the falling thing, the rack of swords that wasn't meant for DeSalvo's and all the questions she wasn't pushing on yet. Yet. Jennifer drank the last of her Diet Coke and listened to all twenty-seven minutes. Chapter Four Council of ElrondJoe's Bar July 31, 1991It was a Wednesday, which was desolate enough that Joe had sent Leonhome early and was running the bar himself. He only did that when theparticular combination of people present made it the right call. Theparticular combination present was: Mac on his usual stool, Methos atthe end of the bar with his third glass of beer, Richie on the stool with thewobble that he'd chosen anyway because it was the right sight line, andFitz — Hugh Fitzcairn, arrived that morning from London via what he'ddescribed as a series of increasingly improbable connections — occupyingthe middle of the bar with the specific energy of a man who intended tomake something of it. Fitz was, as usual, already making something of it. "The thing about the Antioch Chalice," he announced to no one who had asked, "is that everyone who's seen it says it can't possibly be what it appears to be, which is precisely what people said about the last three things I tracked down that turned out to be exactly what they appeared to be.""The Antioch Chalice," Mac said, with the tone of someone who had heardvariations of this sentence from Fitz across several centuries, "is inthe Metropolitan Museum of Art.""That," Fitz said, "is the one they want you to think is the AntiochChalice.""Fitz.""Mac.""It's in the Metropolitan Museum of Art.""And I have a contact in Bruges," Fitz said with serene confidence,"who has documentation suggesting otherwise." He picked up his glass. "Ijust need someone who knows enough about fourth-centu-

ry Syrian metalworkto tell me if the documentation is genuine."Everyone looked at Methos. "No," he said."You haven't heard the terms yet," Fitz said."The terms are irrelevant," Methos said. "The answer is no.""I'll cover the flights.""Still no.""Business class."A pause. "Define business class," Methos said."Methos," Mac objected urging him not to encourage Fitz."I'm just gathering information," Methos said. Joe was already flustered and they really had not even started their meeting.* * *Richie, who had been drinking his coffee withthe expression of someone who had something to say and was choosing hismoment announced, "She plays drums." Everyone looked at him. "Jennifer, sheplays drums. Has been since she was — a while. She's got a practice padin her apartment. Sticks. Big earmuff headphones. She sits on the floorand drums along to records."Joe put his cloth down with the specific deliberateness of a man settingsomething down before he said something he'd been building toward. "Iknow about the drums," he said."You knew?" Richie questioned. The bar was quiet for a moment."Joe," Mac said, carefully."I knew," Joe said again and now there was something in it. He took a hit he'd decided he deserved. "She mentioned it in the first week, offhand. I filed it. And then—" he stopped."And then days went by," Richie said. Not unkindly, just accurately. Joe sighed while conducting an honest internal accounting. "There's akit in the back, Billy's spare. It's been sitting there since March. Ishould have just told her it was there, told her she could play itwhenever. After hours, before open, whenever she needed it. She's beenkeeping the muscle memory alive on a rubber pad and I've had a full kitsitting thirty feet away." He picked up his cloth. "I never got around to saying anything." "Why not?"A pause. "I kept thinking there'd be a right moment," Joe said. "A jam night, aThursday where the lineup had a gap. Something — official." He turnedthe cloth in his hands. "And I kept not making the moment happen. Starting this week she gets the standing invitation. Open bar hours, closed bar hours, whenever. The kit is hers to use." He paused. "And I'm going to tell her directly. Not wait for the right moment, just tell her next time she's in.""After hours," Mac said. "Why not soon? Just — whoever's here. Jenniferon the kit. Joe on guitar. We could—""We," Methos said."I play," Fitz said, with dignity."You play and you sing," Methos said. "I've heard both. The world hasbeen patient with you.""I

play perfectly adequately," Fitz said, "and I have been told my voiceis—""By whom," Methos said."By several people across several centuries who had no reason to—""Fitz," Mac said. "You can play. You can sing." He paused. "Thetambourine."Fitz looked at him."You play the tambourine," Mac said. "You're very good at it.""I could," Fitz said, considering this with more seriousness than itwarranted. "Yes. I could do the tambourine." He paused. "But I'd need amicrophone.""You're playing the tambourine," Richie said. "You don't need amicrophone.""I would need a microphone," Fitz said, "that I could throw around. Tossin the air. Catch. Use for presence." He demonstrated a briefmicrophone-throwing gesture that nearly took out his glass."Absolutely not," Joe said."A good one deserves a good throw," Fitz said."Not in my bar," Joe said."Outside the bar—""Fitz."Fitz subsided. Partially."What about Methos," Richie said. Everyone looked at Methos. Methos had no intention of being assigned to a band by committee."Kazoo," Richie announced with a tone of finality."No," Methos said."You could really lean into it," Richie said."The answer is no.""We could get you a good one," Fitz said. "A quality instrument.""There is no quality kazoo," Methos said. "The kazoo is the denial ofquality. The kazoo is what happens when someone decides music should behumiliating.""So, a kazoo then," Mac chuckled."Absolutely not," Methos said. "I decline the kazoo. I decline any instrument. I would be a significantly better groupie than any of you would be musicians.""You'd be a groupie?" Richie said."An excellent groupie," Methos said. "Knowledgeable, historically informed. I have seen the origins of every musical tradition currently in use and I can appreciate Jennifer's drumming from a position of context that none of you can match." He picked up his glass. "The groupie role is clearly mine." "He's not wrong," Joe commented."I'm never wrong about my own strengths." Methos set his glass down. He looked at Richie and returned to something he had been circling internally. "So, Marsh let you into her apartment?"Richie had a slight smile. "Yeah, she did. We listened to some music, ordered a pizza and talked about almost everything," he replied. "That why we're here, right? To talk about the things Jennifer wasn't pushing me on."Mac nodded. "Yes, we are," he answered recalling the bits of their conversation after the Quickening."The doorstep," Methos started. "Did you kiss her?""No.""Did you want to?"The

expression on Richie Ryan's face lasted approximately one and a halfseconds before he controlled it. He said nothing. Methos nodded. "It was a date, wasn't it?""He got pizza," Joe said. "They listened to records. He walked herhome. What's the big deal?""He walked into her home," Methos said. "He stayed. They talked. She walkedhim to the door. There was a moment." He looked at Richie. "There was amoment."Richie said nothing."There was a moment," Methos said, satisfied, to no one in particular."They're twenty," Joe sighed. "They are," Methos said. "Which means the moment must have been considerable." "Methos," Joe said, with the specific weight of a man who had found theend of his patience. "Whatever she and Richie did or didn't do or might do is their business. Full stop.""Full stop," Methos agreed. And he picked up his glass and he was quiet. Which was, from Methos, as close to graceful as it got. Fitz, who had been half-listening while apparently doing something elseinternally, said, "A good kit, though. For her. If we're doing thisproperly." He paused. "She deserves something real under her hands." Hewas warming to the idea, the bar slightly receding from his attention ashe went somewhere that was entirely about drum specifications. "ALudwig, maybe. Classic. The Vistalite series. Or a DW, Drum Workshop,the Collector's series, the shell hardware on those is—" he trailed off,talking to himself now "—or if she has strong opinions about vintage, alate-sixties Gretsch, the Round Badge era, the shell construction onthose is something that modern kits just don't—"He had, at some point in the last thirty seconds, started humming. It took a moment for anyone to notice. Richie identified it first. He looked at Fitz and then at Mac. Mac was already looking at Fitz and deciding whether to say anything. Fitz, entirely unaware, was humming Lady by Styx. His internal radio had made a selection without consulting him."Fitz," Richie said. Fitz kept humming. "Lady, by Styx."Fitz stopped. He looked at Richie. "I wasn't—" he started."You were," Mac said."I was thinking about drum kits," Fitz said."And humming Styx," Richie said."That's—" Fitz paused. "That's a coincidence.""Is it?" Methos said, with the serenity of a man who collected moments and kept them. Fitz looked at his glass. He picked it up. He set it down."Lady," Joe said."Purely coincidental," Fitz said."And then there's Lionel Richie," Richie said. "Also called Lady. Andthe Tom Jones one—""She's a

Lady," Mac said. "Tom Jones.""Whoa whoa she's a lady," Richie added with some stage presence."And then," Methos said, pleasantly, "there's the Commodores." Everyonelooked at him. "Once, twice, three times a lady.""What does that even mean?""I'm not saying anything," Methos returned. "Lionel Richie is sayingsomething. I'm simply noting the lyrical content.""Fitz," Joe said."I have met her twice," Fitz said, with great dignity. "Briefly. I amsimply appreciating her qualities from an appropriate distance.""While humming three separate songs with lady in the title," Mac said."The subconscious," Fitz replied, "is its own jurisdiction.""A jurisdiction that is apparently extremely well-stocked with soft rock." Joe refilled glasses. The physical actions were automatic, which freed him to think. He stopped. "Can I say something?" he said drawing full attention. "Show the lady some respect."A beat passed."Richie came in here and told us about his evening with Jennifer and you turned it into material." He looked directly at Methos. "Richie is not material and he deserves a little more from the room than this. And so does she."Mac looked at Richie. "He's right," Mac said. Simply. Richie had been fine with the conversation until the point Joe had pointed out the cruelty of something he had been managing. "I'm okay," Richie stated."I know you are," Joe said. "That's not the point.""The point," Methos said, with more care than he usually deployed, "is taken." He looked at Richie. "Apologies."Richie looked at him. "Yeah," he said. After a moment. "Okay."And after a pause, "And she's not a lady," Methos announced. He looked at the expressions around him and made the rapid calculation of someone who had said something that had landed wrong. "I mean—" he started."Methos," Mac growled."Not —" Methos said. "I didn't mean — she is absolutely —" He stopped. Methos collected himself quickly. "What I mean," he said carefully, "is that she is not a lady in the diminutive sense, the small sense, the sense that implies she needs protecting from reality or from her own choices." He looked at Joe. "She is not a lady."Joe was a heartbeat from throwing Methos out of the bar."She is an empress. There is a difference," Methos continued. "A lady is a title, an empress is a condition." He picked up his glass. "I am not diminishing her. I am doing the opposite. I am saying she is entirely capable of deciding what she does and does not want, and does not require any of us to manage the situation on her be-

half.” He paused. “Including the speculation, which I will grant you was in poor taste.”Joe looked at him for a long moment. “Empress,” Joe sighed.“Empress.” Joe warned him not to push it. “Staying right here, no farther.”Mac had processed a great deal of information and was arranging it into something workable. He looked at Richie. “She’ll want to know what she’s walking into when we tell her about all of it.” He paused. “She’s been building the picture. Jennifer’s carefully approached both Richie and me. She deserves to be told straight.” “She will be,” Joe said.“Soon,” Richie added.“Soon,” Mac agreed. Methos said nothing. He had ran the calculation, knew how it had landed and was, for once, keeping it to himself. Joe wrapped both hands around his mug. “So," he said. "We need to talk about Jennifer.”"We've been talking about Jennifer for hours,” Methos commented."We've been talking around her,” Joe said. "We need to talk about the actual thing.""She's going to crack it on her own," Richie announced. "I told you. She'smost of the way already. The swords, the way Mac moves, the notgetting hurt thing." He paused. "She gave me the outline. Jenniferwasn't pushing but she did tell me she already knew where the edges were."“We’re already out of time,” Methos commented referring to the anomaly situation that had occurred with Devon.“He called her an anomaly?” Richie demanded.“Well, not to her face,” Methos returned. “But in all honesty it’s not the wrong word. It’s not a flattering word, but it’s correct. Jennifer Marsh is something we’ve never seen before and others will be interested. We should tell her everything as soon as possible, before anyone else comes nosing around.”"We will tell her," Joe agreed. "The question is who and when and how.""I will,” Mac said."She works for me," Joe said. "She's in my bar. This is my—""She's my student," Mac countered, not aggressively. He was just stating thegeometry."She trusts Richie most right now," Joe said. "That's just true. If we're talking about who she's most likely to—""She trusts all of us," Richie countered. "Differently. That's not the same as more or less.""He's right," Methos said. "She trusts Joe because he hired her, has been straight with her and runs a place she feels safe in," Methos said. "She trusts Mac because he caught her attention immediately and whatever he is to her, it doesn't have an agenda." He paused. "She trusts Richie because he's shown up, fed her, sat on her floor and listened. Those are three different kinds of trust and

they're all legitimate." He looked around the table. "The question is not who she trusts. The question is what she needs and Jennifer will need it to be true. Whatever you say to her has to be unequivocal. No softening it or giving her the version you think she can handle right now. She's been handling it on her own for months, she's done it correctly and she deserves the full picture. All of it. At once. No half measures.""Watchers too," Joe said quietly."Watchers too," Methos agreed. Joe had been a Watcher for most of his adult life and was about to explain it to someone who worked in his bar and would have reasonable questions about the nature of that relationship and what it meant. "That's the harder conversation," Joe said."Yes," Methos said."She'll have thoughts about it," Richie added"She'll have that flat voice about it and then she'll have thoughts," Joe commented. "But we'll tell her together, a united front. Mac, you start — it's your world first and foremost. I'll discuss the Watchers. Richie should be there because she'll want to look at him when it's confirmed. To check her read was right."Mac nodded. "Where?""Here, after close, on turf she knows. Somewhere she already feels like herself.""When?" Richie questioned."Soon," Mac said."This week," Joe said. "Not next week. This week.""She's going to be fine," Methos commented."I know," Mac said. "Jennie is going to be fine."Methos and Harrington'sThe first text from Methos arrived on a Tuesday at half past two in theafternoon. Methos: Have you met the new bartender at Joe's? Jennifer. Remarkablecreature. Thought you should know there have been developments. Amanda looked at her phone. She was in the middle of something. She setit down. It buzzed again. Methos: The council met Wednesday. All very solemn. Mac, Joe, Richie,Fitz — yes Fitz is in town, don't ask — and myself. We discussed thesituation at some length. She picked it up. Amanda: What situation? His response was immediate, which meant he'd been waiting. Methos: The situation of the new girl figuring out rather a lot on herown and what to do about it. Also there may be something developingbetween her and Richie. Early days. But the signs are — significant.I've done some analysis. Amanda looked at her phone. Amanda: What kind of analysis? What followed was three texts in rapid succession that she read withincreasing stillness — the specific stillness of a woman whosetemperature was rising and who was expressing it through the quality ofher not-mov-

ing rather than any movement at all. The council. Wednesday night. The five of them — five men, shenoted, five — sitting at Joe's bar and discussing how to handleJennifer. What she knew, what she didn't know and what she was ready for. How to manage the situation. Richie, the pizza and the records. Methos's analysis of whether it constituted a date. His analysis. She read that part twice. Amanda: You held a council. Methos: It was more of a conversation. You sat around and decided what to do about a woman who has beenfiguring things out entirely on her own. We were being supportive. She is not a situation to be managed. Everyone agreed on that actually. Joe made the point forcefully. Although he did call her a lady first which opened a whole—I don't want to hear about it. The empress thing went over rather well I thought. Methos. Yes. Stop texting me.I haven't told you the best part yet. She looked at her phone. She looked at the ceiling. She looked back ather phone. What? What followed was Methos's account of Fitz humming three separate songswith Lady in the title without realizing it, including the Commodores,including his own subsequent observation about once twice three times alady and what that might mean in context, delivered with the self-satisfaction of a man who considered himself the most perceptive person in any room he occupied. Amanda read it. She put her phone down. She picked it up. She put it down again. She picked it up and typed:I am going to say this once. She is not entertainment. She is a woman navigating something enormous entirely without assistance and instead of any of you actually helping her you held a council and then Fitz hummed the Commodores and you're texting me about it like it's gossip.A pause. To be fair, Methos typed, it is also gossip. Amanda turned her phone off. She sat for a moment. She turned it back on, opened a new message to Mac, and typed:I'm coming to Seacouver next week. Take me to dinner. Harrington's. Thursday. Eight o'clock. She put the phone down. She did not text Methos again.* * *Amanda arrived at Harrington's at five past eight, which was not late. It was the precise calculation of a woman who knew that five past eight in a restaurant such as Harrington's was not tardiness; it was an entrance. Harrington's had been on the corner of Fifth and Clement since 1954, and had never once considered updating the menu or its decor. The walls had dark paneling and leather booths the color of old brandy.

The tablecloths were white and the bar was mahogany. The steaks were the size of decisions. The wine list was a document and the candles were real. Amanda walked in. Not like a flower. Like a bomb. The specific, self-contained, already-detonated quality of a woman who knew exactly what effect she produced and had made her peace with it sometime around the ninth century. The maître d' took her coat. Three people turned to look. Amanda didn't notice, or noticed and categorized it as ambient, which was the same thing. Mac was already there. He stood. He always stood, because the Scottish Highlands had installed certain behaviors that not even Amanda had been able to fully dislodge. She sat down across from him. He looked at her. 'You look—' he started.'I know. Thank you.' Amanda picked up the menu with the efficiency of someone who had already reviewed it online and was confirming rather than discovering. 'I'm furious."'I know,' Mac replied. 'Methos texted me after you stopped responding to him.''What did he say?''He said you'd gone dark and thought he might have miscalculated.''He did,' Amanda confirmed. She set the menu down. 'A council, Mac?''It wasn't—'"Five men deciding how to handle a woman." Amanda glared at him. 'Do you know what she'd say if she knew?''I have an idea.''The flat voice,' Amanda said. 'The one that means the opposite of what it says.''Yes,' Mac said.'I've seen her use it. A customer got ideas about himself. She used the flat voice and he reconsidered without her having to do anything else.' Amanda picked up her water glass. 'She doesn't need managing. She needs to be told the truth and trusted to do something useful with it.''That's what we decided,' Mac said.'After a council.''After a conversation.'Amanda was warm, patient and absolutely immovable. He conceded the point by not arguing it. The sommelier appeared. Amanda ordered without consulting Mac, because she had already decided, and it was the right choice, and he knew it was the right choice before he heard it. This was a reliable pattern. He let it happen.'Tell me about her,' Amanda said, when the sommelier had gone. 'Not Methos's version.'Mac was quiet for a moment. 'She came in knowing nothing and she's been building the picture ever since. Not asking, watching and filing. She has the quality of the ones who can take it and reorganize. Who find out what this world is and don't break.'Amanda looked at him. 'The arm lock.''You knew about that.''Joe,' she said.

“She has the quality, Mac. There aren’t many.’“No, there aren’t.’Something moved through Amanda’s face, the specific briefly unguarded thingshe usually kept behind the performance. ‘And she doesn’t have eyes for you,’ Amanda said. Carefully. ‘In case that was relevant, in case anyone was wondering.’Mac looked at her. “Is that so?”“Methos is convinced she’s going to end up with Richie.” He had been thinking the same thing. “They’d make a lovely couple.”The food arrived. Amanda had ordered the filet, which she ate with the focused appreciation of someone who took good cooking seriously. Mac had the same. They ate in the comfortable silence.‘I’m going to befriend her,’ Amanda said, between the first and second course. ‘She needs someone on her side. Not a handler, not someone managing the situation, someone who is simply on her side.’“You’ve only spoken to her twice, that I know of.”“I like her already. The befriending is inevitable. I’m simply announcing it so no one is surprised.’“Nothing you do surprises me anymore, Amanda.”“She’s going to need people, Mac. When she finds out fully. When it’s not a picture she’s building but a thing she knows. She’s going to need a sisterhood, even if it’s a sisterhood of one to start.’Mac reached across the table and covered her hand with his, briefly. Amanda looked at his hand and turned hers over. The thing between them that never quite got named was present in the way it always was. The candles burned. The wine was exactly what she had said it would be.* * *They were waiting for the valet when Mac simply sighed, “Methos.” Amanda looked at him. ‘He texted you and spilled everything. He knew exactly what he was doing when he did it.’“He always knows what he’s doing,’ Amanda said.‘He’s been watching her since May’ Mac clarified. ‘Longer maybe. He’s done more research on Jennifer than any of us, I’d bet on it. He’s familiar with her history and has known from the beginning that she was going to figure it out.’ He paused. ‘And instead of doing anything about it himself he sent a text to you that he knew was going to make you furious enough to—’“To come to Seacouver and take the situation in hand,’ Amanda said slowly.‘He couldn’t do it himself. That’s not how he operates. He doesn’t step in directly, he arranges. He finds someone else to carry the thing he doesn’t want to carry himself. Methos did the same thing with Kronos. Couldn’t kill his old comrades himself. So he made sure I was in the room.’Amanda was quiet for a

moment. ‘That,’ she said carefully, ‘is a stretch.’“Is it?”She thought about it a second time. ‘It’s probably a stretch,’ she said. ‘But I wouldn’t put it past him.’The valet appeared with the car and the Aston Martin pulled up to the curb with the quiet authority. ‘I have a loft, if you're interested in a nightcap.’ Not a move, not quite. It was the kind of thing that could be interpreted as an afterthought if you were being generous and as something else entirely if you weren’t. Amanda looked at the car and then looked at him. ‘I came by car service.” Mac opened the passenger, Amanda got in and he drove. Chapter Five The TellingJoe’s Bar, After Close Friday NightJoe had asked Jennifer to stay after close on a Friday, which was unusualenough that she had noticed it. The last customer left at 2:15. Jennifer was wiping down the bar when she heard the door open. Mac came in, then Richie behind him, Methos and Amanda. Jennifer looked at the assembled room and then to Joe. She put the cloth down. “Okay,” she said. “What’s happening.” It wasn’t a question. Amanda looked at her with the warm specific attention of someone who had been waiting to be in this room and was glad to finally be there. She smiled. “Come sit down,” Amanda said. “We’re going to talk.”Joe set a bottle on the round table by the stage along with half a dozen glasses. He looked at Jennifer with the expression of a man who had been thinking about this moment and had made his peace with it. Jennifer sat down and started handling the glasses. She poured five healthy portions and served them. Jennifer left the empty glass and bottle near Joe. Rules were rules, no matter what the environment was building. Joe was aware and poured a glass for her. In his mind it wasn’t a night for rules at all as there were bigger fish to fry. The table arranged itself around her intentionally. Joe sat to her left, Mac sat to her right and Richie sat directly across from her. Amanda sat beside Richie on his left, Methos on his right. The round table made it so there was no head, no foot, no hierarchy; just six people in a circle under the low bar light, the bottles behind the bar catching the amber in the distance. Jennifer looked around the circle and then fixed on Richie. He had the expression of someone who knew this was right and was also aware that right didn’t mean easy. She put both hands flat on the table. “All right, what are we doing here?”Amanda folded her hands and looked at her directly. “Before we start, I want to say that everything you’re about to

hear is true and that none of it changes anything about who you are or what you've built here."Jennifer raised her eyebrows. "That's a significant preamble.""It's a significant conversation."Joe cleared his throat."So," he said. "You know how — when you're a kid, and your parents haveto explain certain things about how the world works—""The birds and the bees," Methos said, from across the table."Not helping," Mac interjected."I'm framing it," Methos insisted."We thought," Joe said carefully, "that it might be useful to—""To establish what you already know," Amanda said, cutting cleanlythrough it. "Before we tell you the rest."Jennifer looked at the table. She looked at Joe on her left, Mac on herright — the specific arrangement of it, the flanking, the intentionbehind it. She understood what they'd done and understood why. Jennifer stood and went back to the bar to get her bag. She put her journal on the table. Everyone looked at the journal. "I have a list," Jennifer said."Of course you do," Methos said."I've had it since August and I've been adding to it." Sheopened it to a page near the middle, well-worn, the writing dense andspecific. "I'll go through it. You fillin what I've got wrong and add what I've missed.""All right," Mac said. "Where do you want to start?"Jennifer looked at her list. "First question, how is this possible?""People are born who will become Immortal. They don't knowit. They live mortal lives — they age, they get sick, they havefamilies. And then at some point they die. For the first time." Hepaused. "And they come back. And after that they don't age. And theyheal from almost anything.""Almost," she said."Almost," he said."What's the exception.""Decapitation," he said. "It's the only thing that ends it permanently."She wrote it down. She looked at what she'd written. She looked up. "Why?""We don't entirely know," Mac said. "The honest answer is that nobodyfully understands the origin. There's no scientific explanation thatholds. There's no religious tradition that covers it completely." Hepaused. "It simply is.""That's an unsatisfying answer," Jennifer replied. Mac nodded. "Yes, I know."She wrote something in the margin of her book. "The Game," she said. "Tell me about the Game.""Eventually there can be only one. Immortals fight. They take heads. When you take a head you take the Quickening, the energy, the power, everything that person was, passes to you." He paused. "The last Immortal standing wins the Prize.""What's the Prize?""We

don't know exactly," Mac said. "The power of all of them. Accumulated. The ability to affect the world. For good or for ill, depending on who wins."Jennifer fixed her eyes on him tightly. "That's why it matters, who wins.""Exactly.""And the Quickening," Jennifer continued. "That's what blew the power the night you and Methos were acting so strangely." "Yes, when an Immortal dies the energy releases. It's — not subtle.""I felt it," she said. "In my sternum. I knew something was going to happen before it did.""In our experience that is unusual, that you felt any of it," Mac announced carefully. Jennifer wasn't an anomaly or a finch. "We'll come back to that."She emptied her glass, made additional notes and located her next question. "Holy ground. I heard you say that once to Richie over the phone. You said, find holy ground. What does that mean?"Mac hadn't expected that detail to be in her possession. Jennifer had been listening carefully and gathering facts. "No fighting on holy ground, any holy ground. Church, mosque, temple, sacred site — any tradition, any religion. It holds." He paused. "We don't know why it holds either. It just does. It always has." "That's the mercy rule," she said. "Of the whole thing. That's the one rule that functions like mercy.""Yes," Mac said, quietly. "That's exactly what it is."Holy ground — mercy rule. She underlined it. "What are the other rules?""There aren't any." She looked up and around the table. "One rule, holy ground. Everything else is the Game."She sat with that for a moment. Joe took the moment to refill her glass."How long have you been playing?""Since 1592.""Four hundred years?" Mac nodded. "You're four hundred years old.""Give or take." Jennifer set her pen down and started digging through her bag. "I need a minute if that's okay," she announced standing with her cigarettes."It's more than okay," Amanda reassured. "Take your time. We're here for you and we'll go at your speed."Jennifer nodded and looked at Richie. He was on his feet quickly. She didn't need to ask. He was there.

The Belt Work

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"Dying," Jennifer announced once she was ready to continue. "Does it hurt?""Yes," Mac answered."Every time?""Every time."She looked at Richie. "Twice, so far." Jennifer held his gaze for a moment. Something moved through her face, thereand gone, controlled immediately. She wrote something in the margin ofher journal, didn't read it back and turned the page. "What would happen if everyone just stopped and refused to play?"Methos made a sound that wasn't quite a chuckle. "It's been tried, variations of it. Truces, agreements, they don't hold. Someone always — the Game has its own gravity. You can resist it for a time. You can't escape it indefinitely."She wrote it down. "Funny ways," she said. "Has anyone died in a funny way?"The table shifted almost imperceptibly. The question had landed differently than she'd perhaps intended — or exactly as she'd intended, as a way of releasing something. "I was thrown from a horse in 1743," Mac said, "Fitz startled it.""The horse startled itself," Methos argued."Fitz was there," Mac said. "The whole incident was his doing.""I once drowned in approximately four inches of water," Methos offered steering the discussion away from Fitz who was not present or able to defend himself. "I'd rather not go into the specifics.""I choked," Amanda said pleasantly. "On a grape. 1204. It was embarrassing.""The buzz," she said. "When you are near there's a buzz. I first felt it when Mac came in the bar during my first week. There was a specific quality in the air, an audible pressure." "Yes, the buzz as you've described it is how we sense each other. The Quickening, the energy — it produces a kind of awareness. Between Immortals.""I'm not an Immortal," Jennifer said."No, you're not.""So I shouldn't be able to feel it.""No," Mac said. "You shouldn't.""And yet, here I am feeling the buzz," Jennifer sighed. "What does that make me then?""Something we don't have a proper word for yet," Methos answered. "To the best of my knowledge, our collective knowledge, you're unique, one of a kind. And that fact has already interested others in our wider circle."Mac shot Methos a look. Jennifer saw it. "What do you mean? Who's interested in me?" There was complete silence until she put it together. "Was that Quickening about me the night of the power outage?""Yes,"

Methos answered. Mac was still glaring at him. “She has a right to know.”“I’m not arguing that,” Mac returned. “We have a lot of ground to cover and you’ve launched a bomb into the middle of all of it.”“Which one of you did it?” Jennifer questioned.“I did. You’re my student,” Mac answered as he took her hand in his. “And I would do it again without hesitation.”She emptied her glass again and wrote in her journal. Jennifer wrote for several minutes, looked at what she’d written and continued with her questions. “Am I one of you, just, not yet. Is there a version of this where I haven’t died yet and I’m walking around not knowing?”The silence that followed had a heavy quality. “It’s possible,” Mac said carefully. “Pre-Immortals exist. They live mortal lives until their first death. There’s no way to know for certain until—”“Until I die,” she said. Jennifer sat with that. She sat with it for a long time, long enough that no one spoke, long enough that the bar’s refrigerators audibly hummed. “Okay, let’s come back to all of that, just not now,” Jennifer announced. She looked at her list for the next topic. “How did you all meet each other? How do relationships work in this situation? Can you have children. Are the children Immortal? Have any of you been married? To each other? To mortals? Have any of you been in love with each other?”“That’s several questions,” Joe commented.“I know,” Jennifer said. “Take your time.”What followed was twenty minutes of the most careful, specific,occasionally awkward conversation Jennifer had ever been part of. Machad been married. More than once. To mortals, mostly. The grief of watching someone age when you couldn’t was something Mac described it as something you learned to carry it without putting it down. Amanda had been married several times, she said pleasantly, toa variety of people, across a variety of centuries, and she said it in away that closed the question of whether any of those marriages hadincluded anyone currently in the room without technically answering it. Methos said he had been married many times and left it there. Richie said nothing. He was twenty and had been Immortal for three yearsand had not yet had time to accumulate the particular weight the otherscarried. Jennifer looked at him and understood this and did notpush. Jennifer wrote everything down and then turned a page. “The Watchers,” she said. She looked at Joe.“This one’s mine,” he said.* * *He told her. Joe told her all about the Watchers: the organization, the

tattoo on his wrist hepushed his sleeve up to show her, the mandate to observe and notinterfere, the records that went back centuries, the library thatexisted specifically to document people who couldn't documentthemselves. Jennifer listened. She was very still in the way she was still when she wasprocessing something large. And learning about the Watchers was enormous."You've been watching all of them? Before you knew them, as friends?""MacLeod was assigned to me originally but as you can see, he's a bit of a magnet.""And how does this square with not interfering?""It doesn't. Fraternizing like this is against the rules." Jennifer wrote everything Joe had told her as fast as she could. "Why do the Watchers exist? If it's secret, if only a fewpeople know about the Game. Who are you keeping the records for?""Ourselves, primarily. The knowledge, the history, itmatters. Even if no one outside the organization ever reads it. There'svalue in the record existing.""Of course there is," Jennifer sighed. Her library aspirations lit up like a pinball machine. "Like the Library of Alexandria.""Something like that.""I was there," Methos said. Everyone looked at him. "Alexandria," he said. "I was there." He picked up his glass. "It wasn't one fire. That's a misconception. It was a series of events over several centuries. The knowledge wasn't destroyed all at once. It — diminished. Gradually. Which is somehow worse."Jennifer looked at him. "Of course you were there.""I'm frequently at one place or another."She jotted a few words. "Who is the oldest in this room? Of all known Immortals?"She already knew. She was watching Methos when she asked it. "Me.""How old?""Approximately five thousand years. Give or take a century."Jennifer pounded her third glass of whisky."You're five thousand years old? Five thousand?""Approximately.""And you're spending your Friday night in a bar in Seacouver.""I spend a great deal of time in bars," Methos countered. "It's one ofhumanity's more consistent achievements."She almost smiled. She controlled it. "Is there anyone older?""Not that I know of," Methos said. "I may be the oldest living person onearth."Jennifer sat with it. "That's," she said. She stopped and then started again. "That's a lot.""Yes," Methos said. "It is."Jennifer looked at the next question on her list. "Do you get sick? The Flu? Colds? Do you need vaccines? If Amanda cut all her hair off would it grow back.? Would a limb regenerate or an organ?"Amanda touched her hair involuntarily."We heal

from almost anything. Illness yes, we get sick,briefly. We recover faster than mortals. Vaccines are notnecessary. Our immune systems are—”“Aggressive,” Methos inserted. Mac nodded. “Hair grows back. Limbs? There are limits. If there’s significant damage probably not.” “Money,” she announced. “Has having enough money ever been a problem?”“In the beginning, less so over time. You accumulate, you learn and you plan for the future.”“I’ve stolen a great deal,” Amanda said pleasantly. “To make ends meet.”“Amanda.”“She asked,” Amanda said.“Have you met anyone famous or witnessed historical events?”What followed was another twenty minutes that Jennifer would laterdescribe, in the margin of her journal, as genuinely unhinged. Mac hadmet Napoleon. Methos had opinions about Caesar that he delivered asthough they were personal rather than historical, which they were. Amanda had danced with a king whose name she declined to specify. Richiehad met exactly one famous person. He said it was a racing contact inEurope and wouldn’t elaborate.* * *She turned another page. She looked at it. She looked up.“Recreational drugs,” she said. The table shifted slightly in the way it shifted when a question landedthat nobody had been expecting.“Does alcohol work,” she said. “We established that. What about otherthings. Weed. Harder stuff.” Methos set his coffee down with the expression of a man who had beenwaiting for this question since approximately the beginning of theevening and was not going to pretend otherwise.“Alcohol works,” Mac said. “Metabolizes faster than in mortals. You needmore to maintain the effect and it doesn’t last as long.”“Richie confirmed this,” Jennifer said, not looking at Richie.“Richie confirmed this,” Mac agreed, also not looking at Richie. Richie looked at the ceiling.“Cannabis,” Methos said, with the tone of someone consulting a very longpersonal archive. “Works. Same principle — the healing factormetabolizes it faster, the window is shorter, the effect while it lastsis comparable to the mortal experience.” He paused. “I’ve been aware ofcannabis preparations since approximately 2700 BCE. The Scythians usedit in funeral rituals. The Egyptians had medical applications. By thetime it became recreational in the Western sense I’d already had severalthousand years of context.” “That’s not what she asked,” Amanda said pleasantly.“I’m providing context,” Methos said. “Does it work or not,” Jennifer said.“It works,” Methos said. “Briefly.”“Harder things,” Jen-

nifer said. “Opiates. Cocaine.”“Work,” Mac said. “Briefly. The healing factor burns through them fasterthan a mortal would. Physical dependency—” he paused. “The body resets. It’s harder to become physically addicted because the healing keepsoverriding it.”“Harder but not impossible,” Methos said, with the flatness of someonebeing accurate about something unpleasant. “In extreme circumstances. Over a long enough period.” He looked at his coffee. “I’m speakinghistorically.”Nobody pushed on that.“Psychedelics,” Jennifer said.A specific silence. Mac looked at the ceiling. Amanda looked at her wine. Richie looked at his hands.“Yes,” Methos said.“Yes they work or yes you have something to say about them,” Jennifersaid.“Both,” Methos said. “They work. And—” he paused, choosing the wordswith the care of someone who had learned that some things needed preciselanguage “—the experience is different. For someone who has lived a verylong time. The — architecture of the mind that a psychedelic interactswith is larger. More complicated. More populated.” He turned his glass.“A mortal takes peyote and confronts their childhood. Their fears. Theirsense of self.” He paused. “I take peyote and I am confronted with fivethousand years of accumulated experience simultaneously. It is—” anotherpause “—not recreational.”The table was quiet.“Have you,” Jennifer said.“Once,” Methos said. “A very long time ago. In a ceremonial context.” Hepicked up his coffee. “I don’t recommend it. Not at my age.”“What about Mac,” Jennifer said. Mac looked at her.“I’m asking,” she said.“Once,” Mac said. “In 1968. San Francisco.” He paused. “I don’trecommend it either.”“Richie,” Jennifer said.“I’m twenty,” Richie said. “I haven’t been Immortal long enough to havecomplicated interior architecture.”“Was that a no,” Jennifer said. Richie looked at his hands.“That was a not yet,” he said. Jennifer wrote something in her journal. She looked at it. She almostsmiled. She turned the page.* * *Jennifer turned to the last entry on her list and started in on her fourth glass.“We’ve already discussed whether knowing any of this puts me in danger, and clearly it does for experiencing things that make me unique.”“As well as knowing us. Knowing puts you in proximity. There are those whowould use that fact alone whether they knew about your extra qualities.” Methos looked at her steadily. “It’s a real risk. You should know it’s real.”“But you’re not alone here,” Mac added warmly. “We’re not going to let any of this

touch you if we can prevent it.”“How?”“By making sure the people who matter in this world know that you matterto us,” Mac said. “That you’re not a lever. That using you would be inadvisable.”“Is that a euphemism?”“Yes.”Jennifer looked at her list, at the bottom of the page and closedthe journal. She was quiet for a moment but the entire late night conversation started to overwhelm her. “Does anyone want to tell me how I’m supposed to —” she stopped. Started again. “I’ve been building thispicture. I knew something was, I knew. But knowing that you knewsomething and having someone sit across from you and tell you that theworld is four hundred years older than you thought it was and alsopossibly you might be—” she stopped again.“Take your time,” Amanda said. Jennifer put both hands flat on the table. “Okay, I need a minute.” She stood, was slightly wobbly and sat back down.“When’s the last time you ate?” Richie questioned. He was not satisfied with her answer. “We need to get you something to eat.”“Yes, at your weight, 95 to 100 kilos I’d estimate, you’re over the legal limit already and probably won’t be sober until dawn, give or take a hour.” Jennifer was sober enough to do the math. “One hundred kilos? Are you out of your mind? Try 85 on a bloated day, at most,” Jennifer objected. “We’re getting off track here,” Mac interjected. “You’d think an old man would know better than to bring up a woman’s weight,” Joe scolded. “She isn’t a delicate blossom in need of a fainting couch,” Methos argued trying to spin his assessment of her body size as a real nod to women’s lib. “I’m speaking in purely scientific terms here.” “Now we’re really getting off track.”Methos produced a genuine smile and spoke from the heart. “I’m not purposely being impolite in today’s common protocols. I don’t care how much you weigh, Marsh, you’re gorgeous. You have the build of an Ishtar sculpture.” When Jennifer didn’t react he added other examples, “Nigella Lawson, Salma Hayek, Sophia Loren. Gorgeous.”“I must really be drunk. Methos thinks I’m gorgeous.”“Any red-blooded straight man would.”“The Comet’s open,” he announced. “Let’s go get something to eat.”The Comet7th and Haines — Approaching DawnThey went to the Comet because it was two blocks away, open and hadpie. They took the big booth. Bev appeared, took one look at the assembledtable, and poured coffee without being asked and left without comment,which was the correct response. Jennifer had her

journal open on the table. She had more questions. The questions came in no particular order. She questioned how many times Mac had died and he reported that he did not have an exact number as he'd lost count somewhere in the second century. She asked Methos if he still had to sleep. He informed her he not a vampire, but agreed the comparison was understandable. Could they get drunk — yes, briefly, it metabolizedfaster than in mortals, which Richie confirmed with the expression ofsomeone who had learned this the hard way. Did it hurt every time they died. Every time, Mac said. Yes. Even the funny ones. Even the funny ones. Though sometimes the humor was retroactive. Jennifer wrote everything down. She ate a turkey club and fries without looking at it. "Do you have other friends, Immortal friends, that I haven't met?""Yes," Mac said. "Several.""How under wraps do I have to keep all of this?""Completely," Mac said. "From everyone outside this world. It's not, it's not safe for this to be wider than it is.""What are the questions I should be asking that I haven't?" Jennifer asked as she continued eating her sandwich. "The ones I don't know to ask at this point. What's missing from my list?"She opened her journal to a fresh page, put her pen on it and waited. Joe spoke first. "You should ask whether there's already a file onyou in the Watcher archives. Whether someone's been assigned to you." He paused. "The fact that you're in proximity to this many Immortals means it'sa question with a horizon. Add in your anomaly and I'm almost certain there will be records regarding you."She wrote down the word anomaly. *I'm the anomaly.*Amanda spoke next. "You should askvwhat it costs. Being the person whoknows." She looked at Jennifer directly. "Not the danger — you askedabout that. I mean the other thing. The way you'll be at every birthdayand we won't age. The way you'll watch Richie look exactly like helooks now in ten years and twenty years and you'll—" she stopped. Shepicked up her wine. "You should ask what it costs to love people whodon't change when you do. And you should ask it before you need to knowthe answer, not after."Jennifer's pen was still. She looked at Amanda for a moment. Somethingmoved through her face and she wrote it down."You should ask if I'll remember you." He said itquietly, to the table rather than to her. "In fifty years. When you're—"he stopped. He started again. "Immortals accumulate a lot, a lot ofpeople. You should ask whether the peo-

ple we meet — themortals we—" he stopped again. Richie looked directly at her. "Whether we remember. Whether it matters the same way." He paused. "The answer is yes. In caseyou were going to ask that next."Jennifer looked at him. She wrote it down. Mac looked at his Scotch. He looked at the table. He looked at her."You should ask what happens to you if the pre-Immortalthing is real. If you are one of us and just haven't died yet." Hepaused. "Not what happens physically — we covered that. What happens tothe life you've been building. The degree you're working toward. The personyou're becoming right now." He turned his glass. "Because if it's truethen at some point that person stops, and a different version of thatperson starts. And the question of what you want to have done and beenand built before that happens is the most important question on yourlist." He looked at her steadily. "You should be asking it now. Notbecause it's urgent. Because it deserves time."The table was very quiet. Jennifer wrote it down. She wrote for longer than the others. She lookedat what she'd written. She didn't look up immediately. Methos turned his coffee mug on the table. He looked at it. He looked ather. "You should ask why you." He said it simply, without drama."Not as a complaint, not existentially, practically. Of all the bars inall the cities in the world, you walked into Joe's. You came fromSeattle, which is where the coffee is better and where you could havestayed. You ended up here, in this city, in this bar, in proximity tothis particular group of people, with the specific quality you have andthe specific ability to feel a thing that mortals aren't supposed tofeel." He picked up his coffee. "The universe does not appear to besubtle. You should ask why you are here, whether the answer mattersand what you intend to do with it." He paused. "I've been asking myselfa version of that question for five thousand years. I don't have ananswer. But the question is worth carrying." The diner went on being itself around them. The refrigerators hummed. Bev moved through the room. Someone at the counter laughed at something. Jennifer looked at her journal. She had filled the page. She looked atthe five answers — Joe's, Amanda's, Richie's, Mac's, Methos's — fivedifferent shapes of the same enormous thing. She closed the journal. She looked at the pie case."Can I get the coconut cream," she said to the table. Bev appeared as if summoned."Coconut cream," Jennifer said. Bev wrote it down and left. Jennifer put

her hands flat on the table. She looked at them. She lookedup."Okay," she said. The real okay. The one that meant she'd heard everything, filedeverything, was going to carry all of it forward, and was ready — notfor it to be resolved, not for it to be simple, just ready — to take thenext step into whatever this was. Bev came back with the pie. It was, as previously established, correct. Jennifer ate it. Outside Her BuildingRichie drove her home on the motorcycle. He had two helmets knowing a co-rider situation was more than probable. Upon arrival Jennifer reached into her bag. She found the cigarettes, lit one and offered one to Richie. "You don't smoke in the apartment," Richie commented."It's good to have some boundaries," Jennifer answered. "I might be able to quit some day if I run out of places I allow myself to smoke.""Quitting is a good idea. Those things will kill you.""But not you," Jennifer sighed. "Have you ever laid your bike down?""If you ride long enough you eventually have to put it down.""Bad?""Once, pretty bad. I had to quit racing. Everyone thought I had died. You can't come back to life in the public eye.""No, I guess you can't.""I'm not going to let anything happen to you," Richie said. "I know."Jennifer finished her cigarette. She looked at the ember, dropped it andput it out with her boot. She looked at her building and then at Richie. And then she turned and she put her arms around him completely. Richie caught her, his arms around her, one hand at the back of her head, and they stood on the sidewalk. Jennifer was shaking slightly but Richie was solid. Neither of them said anything because nothing needed to be said.*Take that, Methos*After a moment Jennifer pulled back. She looked at him. Her eyes were clear."Would you—" she started. She stopped. She looked at the building. Shelooked at him. "Would you stay? Tonight. Just—" she paused. "I don'twant to be alone. It doesn't have to be—""Yeah," he said. Before she finished. "Obviously."She looked at him. "Obviously.""Come on," he said. "Three flights.""Forward weight.""Forward weight." Apartment 308LateJennifer made coffee for them both, sat on the floor and Richie sat besideher. She leaned her head against his shoulder and neither of them said anythingfor a long time. Richie noted she had stopped shaking but that didn't mean she wasn't rattled."Do you want something stronger?" Richie questioned"Have you got anything—"Jennifer laughed. It was the first real laugh in hours and arrived from some-

where that had been closed for most of the evening and was apparently open now. She laughed and put her hand over her mouth and looked at him. “I don’t have money for a bag of chips,” she said. “How would I have money for weed?”Richie just looked at her.“I’m serious,” she said. “I have coffee and a lime presiding over my refrigerator.“That’s the full inventory.”“Your priorities are mixed up,” he commented.“My priorities,” she said, “are correct. The weed budget did notsurvive the move.”“I’m just saying there’s a hierarchy.”“Coffee, records, board,” she said. “In that order. Everything else isnegotiable.”“And yet you smoke Marlboros.”“Marlboros are an emergency item,” she said. “Not a luxury item. Different column.”Richie looked at her. The smile was still there — the real one, the one thathad come up from somewhere real. “You should do that more,” he said.“Smoke Marlboros?”“Laugh,” he said. She looked at him. Something settled in her face — not the filingexpression, not the flat voice, just — something quiet and present andreal. “Yeah,” she said. “Okay.”“We should get some sleep,” Jennifer announced. “Mac’s still going to expect me to show for training.” Richie moved first and announced that he would just need a blanket on the floor.“Get in the bed.”“I’m fine on the floor.”“Richie, bed,” Jennifer groaned. “It’s a queen. There’s room. I’m not asking you to—”“I know,” he said. Richie took a deep breath. “But I would like it on the record that those services are available on request.”“Raincheck, please.” Jennifer pushed a smile because it was a perfect line, a line she planned on using in the future. “Just be here. Hold me.”Richie looked at her for a moment. It was right, it was good and it was iswhat she needed from him in the moment. “Okay.”They lay in the dark in her bed in apartment 308. Richie held her allnight and at some point she fell asleep. Jennifer smelled like berries. Strawberries, specifically. He’d noticed it before — in the stairwell,on the floor listening to records — and had filed it the way he filedthings about her, which was carefully and without comment. Once she was fully asleep Richie closed his eyes. DeSalvo’sSaturday MorningMac was already there when they arrived. He was running through a form alone in the empty dojo. He stopped when he heard them on the stairs. Mac looked at Jennifer and then at Richie. Mac said, with the mild certainty of someone whose senses did not lie, “You both smell like cigarettes.”“I smoked,” Jennifer said flatly. “You may not have noticed but I

have recently been under an incredibleamount of stress.""I was smoke adjacent," Richie offered. "She smells like strawberries, from my end, for what it's worth."Jennifer was already moving toward the mat. She was running on fourhours of sleep and generalized momentum. Jennifer was almost at the edge ofthe mat when Richie said, Shoes."She stopped, looked at her feet and then at the mat. "Right," she said. Not embarrassed — just accurate. "Right."Jennifer went back to the door. She sat on the small bench to take hershoes off and her left hand missed the bench entirely on the firstattempt and she listed sideways. Richie was there; both hands,clean, no hesitation, one at her shoulder and one at her arm and sheended up briefly against him, caught, upright. She was still for a moment. "I'm fine.""I know," he said. He didn't let go for another second. Just long enough. Jennifer straightened. She got her shoes off, set them by the door inthe correct position, lined up, toes pointing out, which was the rightway and she knew it and had just — forgotten, for a moment, because shewas still in it and would be in it for days probably. That was to be allowed. She stood up, looked at the mat and back at Richie. "Go," she said. "I'mgood."He looked at her with directness. "I'll call you later." Richie picked up his board. He looked at Mac once — theshorthand nod, and went out the door. Jennifer turned to Mac. She took a deep breath and bowed. He returnedit. "We'll start with our meditation."I am still. I can hear my heart beat.I am still. I can hear my heart beat.I am still. I can hear my heart beat. Mac waited patiently for her to stand, but as she was clearly in a roughstate he quietly said, "You did well last night.""I had a list." Eyes closed, still breathing."I know. The list was good."Jennifer took one more deep breath before slowly opening her eyes. "Thepre-Immortal thing, the buzz," Jennifer stated. "You really don't knowwhat it means?""I really don't but I'm going to find out." Mac looked at her steadily. "Whatever it means — you're not navigating it alone. That's not conditional on what it turns out to be." Mac suggested that they run katas. Chapter Six Her 20th Birthday Tuesday started at seven. Jennifer had slept as long as she could and stillget her morning routine in before heading to the dojo to train with Mac. Richie and Mac were sparring. She bowed in and had a seat on the floorto watch. When Mac saw her waiting patiently he told Richie that theyshould start wrapping up their ses-

sion. Jennifer lined up once Richiehad cleared the floor and greeted Mac."Good morning, Jennie. Let's begin with our meditation."I am still. I can hear my heartbeat. Three times. Training with Mac that day was devoted to getting the footwork in alonger progression correct. Mac corrected her three times and shestarted over three times before getting it on the fourth try. Thevictory was short lived as Mac wanted to make sure she had gotten it,not just gotten lucky. Again. Again. Again. Mac was like that. The lesson ended as it began, meditation and a bow. Mac wished her agood day at school. Jennifer had the specific satisfaction of a bodythat had been worked and knew it. She left DeSalvo's into the August morning with her bag over one shoulder and her board under her arm. She had forty minutes before she had to be on campus. Jennifer went into the record store on Morrison Street for two reasons. The first, because it was on the way to the bus stop and secondly shehad been wanting an occasion to go in and spend a little money. Ten. Pearl Jam. Jennifer picked it up, turned it over and read the tracklisting. Jennifer bought it. She tucked it in her bag with the textbooks. She got onthe bus and sat in the back and looked at the sleeve the whole ride to campus.*This weekend. I'll listen to it over the weekend.** * *Jennifer was mid-shift when Richie came in, coffee, as usual. She set it infront of him without being asked. Richie reached into his jacket pocket and put something on the bar, a small bag with a twist-tie. He pushed it across to Jennifer. After a brief examination she realized it was full of chocolate covered coffee beans, the good kind, from the shop two blocks over that she'd mentioned once in passing that she'd been meaning to try.'Happy birthday,' Richie announced in a whisper. She went very still for a moment. 'How did you know?''Dojo forms,' he said. 'Thank you, Richie." She put the bag in her apron pocket. She went back to work. Jennifer came back his way on her next pass and refilled Richie's coffee.'I bought something today,' she said. Not to him specifically, just aloud. 'Pearl Jam, new album. Ten. Came out today.''Yeah, I heard about it.''I haven't listened yet,' she said. Already moving, wiping down the bar. 'I'll get to it this weekend probably.''Probably.''School's only two weeks in,' she said, with the tone of someone reporting a condition rather than complaining about it. 'I'm already behind on the reading and I have a paper due Thursday. This weekend, I'll listen to

it this weekend.''How many times?' Richie chuckled. 'How many times will you listen to it, over the weekend.'She thought about it honestly. 'Twice,' she said. 'Maybe three times if it's what I hope it is.'Jennifer kept the bag of chocolate covered coffee bean in her apron for the whole shift. She ate one at closing. Just one. She saved the rest. Saturday August 31, 1991 Apartment 308Classes at the dojo ran into the early afternoon. Jennifer swept once the floor was free. Richie assisted with the clean up and then locked the space for the weekend. They walked out together into the August afternoon, boards under theirarms. Jennifer announced her plans without looking at him. 'I'm going to listen to the album tonight,' she said. 'If you wanted to come over.'He looked at her sideways. 'Yeah,' he said. 'Okay.' Jennifer stopped at the Golden Dragon on the way home. She had gotten paidThursday and the refrigerator had actual food in it for once. Sheordered with the specific intentionality of someone planning for theweekend — enough for tonight and tomorrow and probably Monday if she wascareful. Wonton soup. Fried rice. Beef and broccoli. Spring rolls. Pork-dumplings because the pork dumplings at the Golden Dragon were stellar. She had enough money in her pocket that week to acknowledge their greatness. Jennifer put everything in the refrigerator except for the spring rolls. She ate those standing at the kitchen counter because Jennifer had earned them. She changed into jeans and a flannel, made coffee and put the album on the coffee table Mac had ordered from Costco. She waited.* * *Richie knocked at six. He entered with a six-pack of Orangina and a bag from the corner store containing chips, the good kind, and a box of the chocolate covered almonds she didn't know he'd noticed her looking at the previous Tuesday. Richie set the bag on the counter with the ease of someone who was not making anything of any of it. She looked at the Orangina, the almonds and didn't say anything. 'You said you had food.''I have food,' Jennifer confirmed as she opened the refrigerator. Richie greeted Admiral Stowie and the super ball. "Admiral's looking a little tired," Richie mentioned before he saw the containers stacked on the shelves. 'Golden Dragon,' he sighed with appreciation.'Golden Dragon.''The dumplings,' he said with hopeful eyes.'Obviously the dumplings."Jennifer got plates and Richie got the containers. They ate at the coffee table on the floor. The wonton soup was exactly right and the

dumplings were perfectly the dumplings. Jennifer had picked up fortune cookies at the counter on the way out, ahandful of them, more than two people needed, because fortune cookies were inexpensive and fun.‘Birthday fortune first,’ Richie announced before pushing the pile toward her. ‘You’re twenty, birthday fortune.’ He said it the way he said things that were already decided. She picked one and cracked it open. Jennifer looked at the slip of paper and then at him.‘ You will find what you seek when you stop looking for it,’ she read. He considered it. ‘That’s not bad,’‘It’s not bad,’ she agreed. She ate the cookie. Richie picked his, read it and his expression fluctuated. ‘What?’‘Adventure awaits the one who is bold enough to ask,’ Richie announced. ‘The cookie knows,’ he said, with the complete gravity of someone delivering a verdict.‘The cookie knows nothing,’ she said. ‘The cookie is a vehicle for a paper slip printed in bulk in a factory in New Jersey.’‘The cookie,’ he said, ‘knows.’She ate a dumpling. He ate a dumpling. They worked their way through the rest of the fortune cookies betweenbites — three more apiece, the fortunes ranging from the genuinelyapplicable to the cosmically vague to one that said simply persistencepays off which Richie held up with the expression of a man receivingconfirmation of a long-held position. ‘See,’ he said.‘Put the cookie down,’ she said. He put the cookie down. He was smiling. She was managing her face with considerable effort and not entirely succeeding. When the plates were cleared, the containers were back in therefrigerator and they were on the floor, Richie decided the moment was right.‘Well, now that you’ve had your birthday meal, your birthdayalmonds and birthday fortune cookies, it’s probably time for your birthdayspanking.’ He held it. The full Richie deadpan, completely committed, waiting tosee what she did with it.‘It’s not time for that,’ Jennifer eventually replied.‘I can clearly see I hit a nerve,’ he said. ‘Tell me what’s going through your mind.’She looked at him for a moment. ‘Exactly?’‘To the letter.’‘It’s not time for that yet because if I crawled across your lap for some carnal pleasure we would end up in bed for the rest ofthe weekend, minimum. And it would be incredible, but I wouldn’t get any of my work done.’ She paused. ‘And most importantly I don’t want to hurt you. I want to take this carefully, slow.”She said it straight from the hip. No softening, no management, the true thing, out loud, in the air between them. He nodded.

‘All right, how about a birthday kiss then.”It wasn’t a question but just what the moment could hold. His offer was simple with complete understanding of everything she’d just said. Jennifer nodded. He made the move. It was the right size for what it was. The distance resolved itself, he kissed her and she kissed him back. It was certain and quiet and completely unsurprising to either of them. When they stopped Jennifer looked at his eyes and he looked back. Neither of them said anything. Jennifer got up and set the needle back to the beginning of the Pearl Jam record. She sat back downbeside him, closer than before, both of them acknowledging this without acknowledging it. Alive came out of the speakers for the third time that evening. They sat in the post-kiss quiet for a while. The good kind of quiet. Somewhere between the fifth and sixth track, Richie made a formal announcement, “For the record. Birthday spankings that are tabled are subject to compound daily interest.”Jennifer let herself laugh. ‘Not worried about that in the least,’ she said, “when the time is right.” ‘When the time is right,’ he agreed. They looked at each other for one more beat and the album played. Richie left at eleven. She walked him to the door. ‘So, Saturday next week,” he announced. Jennifer nodded and echoed him in agreement. “Did you want another one before I go?” “Yes, please, one more.”It was a very gentle goodbye kiss. Jennifer stood in the doorway until she heard the building door close. She went back inside with a smile on her face and put the record on for the fourth time. Jennifer made the last coffee of the day and sat on the floor. She got out her notebook and wrote four pages.*I didn’t want to listen to it without him. I think I’ve known that since Tuesday.*Jennifer put the notebook away, listened to the end of the record and went to bed. Richie rode home with the August night and heard the lyrics of a song that did not exist, When the Time is Right, playing in his head. In contrast the specific jurisdiction of his subconscious had apparently decided to editorialize, with Rick James. She’s a very kinky girl. He told his subconscious to knock it off. His subconscious played the chorus again. Richie rode home smiling the whole way.

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"Come stand here," Mac said. He was in the center of the mat, positioned, waiting. Jennifer stood beside him. "Mirror me," he said. "Don't think about it. Just mirror." Mac moved through the first kata slowly, the specific deliberate sequence she'd been watching him run alone at the beginning of sessions for weeks; the one she'd been filing without knowing she was filing it. Jennifer mirrored him. Mac stopped after the third movement. "You've been watching this," he said. She said she had. “How long?” "Since the first session," Jennifer answered. Mac looked at the position she was holding; correct, specific, her body having retained something her brain hadn't consciously processed. "Again," he said. "From the beginning." They ran it together, side by side, and Jennifer felt the depth of moving in synchrony with someone who had been doing the same movement for years. The was an absolute economy of it, the absence of anything extra and how her own body was starting to understand what economy meant. "The kata is not the destination," Mac said, as they moved. "The kata is the conversation. You're learning the vocabulary so that eventually you won't need to think about the words." She kept moving. "Like rudiments in drumming," she said. He looked at her briefly, still in motion."Yes," he said. "Exactly the rudiments.”

What Richie Told Her: Tessa

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WHAT RICHIE TOLD HER: TESSA The East Side Park — A Sunday It was their day off and she was at the east side park on her board and Richie was there, which had become the Sunday rhythm. They’d been there two hours and were cooling down, sitting on the concrete edge with water bottles, when she said: “Richie.” “Yeah.” “Who was she?” she said. “There’s someone Mac lost. Someone specific. Someone mortal. I’ve been

watching him and there's a shape of something in him that I don't have context for." Richie was quiet for a long moment. He turned his water bottle in his hands. "Her name was Tessa," he said. "Tessa Noel." And he told her. He didn't tell it like a story. He told it the way she'd expected — in pieces, not in order, the details that had stuck. Tessa was an artist. She was French. She'd been with Mac for years — a mortal, knowing what he was, choosing him anyway. She'd been warm in a way that had made the people around her warmer. She'd been shot. A random thing — a robbery, a wrong place, a wrong moment. Jennifer listened without interrupting. When he finished she was quiet for a long moment. "He teaches me the way he does," she said, "because of her." Richie looked at her. "He watched someone mortal who was brilliant and capable and it wasn't enough," Richie explained. "So now when he finds someone mortal who's in his world, he gives them every tool he has. Not because the tools would have saved her. But because it's what he can do." "Yeah," Richie said, after a moment. "Yeah, that's completely right." "He calls me Jennie," she said. "From the fourth day. Like it was already there." She paused. "Did he call her anything? A specific name?" "He called her Tessa," Richie said. "Just Tessa. But the way he said it —" He stopped. "You could hear it." She nodded. She understood this. "Thank you," she said. "For telling me." They skated for another hour. Walking out she said: "She sounds like someone I wou Chapter Seven — The Broom LadyAutumn, SaturdayThe first children's class began at nine on Saturdays. Jennifer was slightly behind schedule and bowed in quickly. Her intention had been to get there before the kids and sweep the floor. The sound of fourteen children between the ages of six and ten acknowledged her in various, expressive ways. She looked at them with a smile and then to Mac. "Sensei, I'm sorry. I can come back for the-""The floor needs sweeping," Mac said. He had already turned back to the class. Jennifer went and got the broom. She swept the corners first, the wayshe'd learned. She was aware of the class behind her without watchingit. She kept her back to them and worked the broom with the rhythm she'ddeveloped over months of sweeping."Who is that?" said a voice. High, small, definitive. The voice of a child accustomed to asking questions and receiving answers."That," Mac said, "is Jennifer. She trains here, just like you.""Why does she have a

broom?" the same voice said."Because the floor needs sweeping," Mac said. Simplest answers were the best. There was a longer pause, during which Jennifer could feel the specificquality of a group of children reassembling their understanding of thesituation. "She's the Broom Lady," said a different voice. A boy'svoice, aiming for funny. Jennifer kept sweeping. She heard Mac say, ”Eyes forward." The classreturned to its business. She returned to her business, caught up with her duties, put the broom away and bowed at the threshold. Jennifer was halfway down the stairs when she heard one of the studentscall out, “Bye, Broom Lady."She did her best to hold it together. Jennifer’s new nickname became Broomie within two weeks. By the third Saturday she arrived to sweep she was Broomie, said with the comfort of a name that had been in use long enough to feel natural. Jennifer filed this and kept sweeping. The First Time Friday, November 13, 1991

The First Time

By coincidence, Jennifer and Richie both showed up to Joe's wearing t-shirts that mentioned luck. Jennifer's was a grey soft blend with the Guinness logo that stated, "I feel lucky." The after-dojo t-shirt Richie had packed was a bit more crass: "I am getting lucky."Once Richie had taken off his jacket Jennifer burst out laughing. "Well, I guess it's official then," she announced, displaying the text on her own shirt. "Tonight's the night."No one else in the bar was treating Friday the 13th as a holiday to be celebrated. That was part of what made them the charming couple that they were. Jennifer served Richie a long neck and removed the reserved sign. What had once been just a sticker had evolved into a Lego board — red, with small white lettering: RESERVED. She had rigged a small bead connector to each side and the plastic sign did its job with dignity. When Joe had lost the battle on the reserved stickers he knew the war was a lost cause. Friday night rolled along as most of them did. The music was a little heavier and people were more likely to dance, which made

serving drinks and appetizers somewhat more challenging. Jennifer just waltzed through the crowd carefully to deliver items and clear her tray. Whenever she had a moment she checked on Richie, and when he was ready to switch to coffee she brewed a new pot. That often covered them for the remainder of the night. Any snacks Leon had prepared for Jennifer were set out in her space. It was fascinating to watch her juggle as much as she did. At the end of the shift Jennifer had put two regulars into cabs and had cut off an unfamiliar patron. When she received the smallest bit of flack she handed it to Joe. When he wasn't there she never argued and simply put in a phone call. Bars that allowed bad behavior had a way of turning into bars with brawls and broken interiors. When forced to call, Jennifer always made two cups of coffee and set them on the bar top with a box of chocolate chip cookies. It was a signal she had worked out with local law enforcement in Seacouver and wasn't a weapon she had to deploy often. That meant from time to time there were cookies getting near their expiration date, and Friday the 13th in November turned out to be such an occasion. When the bar officially closed at two in the morning Jennifer and Richie were the only ones left. Jennifer had a breve — hot, whole milk — and broke open the cookies, offering some to Richie. Richie grabbed a cookie and assisted where he could in the closing. The sooner the bar was done the sooner they could get on with their weekend plans."I don't want to go back to my apartment tonight," Jennifer announced. "I have clothes at Zed and your place is not only closer but bigger.""Okay," Richie agreed. Wherever she wanted to be he wanted to be there too."We're taking these cookies with us?""Obviously."* * *"I'm going to need to borrow something to sleep in," Jennifer announced as she set everything she'd been carrying onto the coffee table. Richie watched her do the bra removal technique that ended with her right hand popping through her right sleeve."I think you may be up to no good tonight," Richie commented as he kicked off his shoes. "You demanded to be brought here, used cookies to lure me in even further, and now your unmentionables are just flying off your body. What's a guy to think?""That he's really lucky," Jennifer managed, "and that he should not eat all the cookies."Richie went to the shelves and came back with a flannel shirt — soft, worn, large enough — which he handed to her without comment. She took it.

She looked at him."Thank you," she said. "For tonight.""You don't have to —""I'm thanking you," she said. "Accept it.""Okay," he said. "You're welcome."Richie undid her braid first. He did not fumble, was not tentative and her hair fell around her shoulders. Jennifer closed her eyes for a moment. The release of the braid, the long shift finally finished and Richie's hands were careful yet certain."I've been wanting to do that for months," Richie sighed with a smile."I know," she said. Jennifer pulled back enough to look at him. "You watched me take it down once at close and you ended up staring at your coffee for four minutes."He stared at her. "You counted the minutes.""I count things," she said. "You know this about me."He looked at her — her hair loose, the flannel shirt, the bar-close hour — and he said: "Jennifer.""Yeah.""I have been paying attention to you since the day you came into the parking lot with Mac," he said. "And when I'm paying attention to something I am very thorough about it."She looked at him. At the blue eyes with the full warmth in them, unmanaged. At the light hair and the line of his jaw. "Good," she said. "I want thorough."* * *The bed was, as she'd expected, properly made, the sheets clean and everything done with care. She appreciated this in the same way she appreciated competence. Richie was paying attention the way he'd said he would be. Thorough was, it turned out, exactly the right word. He was unhurried and he watched her face the way he watched everything he cared about — completely, taking information, being present about it — and when she said things he listened. When she moved toward something he followed."Your eyes," she said, at some point."What about them?""In this light." She looked at him — the blue of them, specific, the exact shade she'd been filing since month three. "I've been aware of your eyes since day one. I want you to know that."He kissed her instead of answering, which was the right answer.* * *After, she lay in the dark and listened to the rain on the window, the soft Seacouver kind, and felt the specific quality of the night. It was real in the way the things she'd been most careful about were always real when she finally allowed them to be."Jennifer," he said."Yeah.""You okay?""Yes, I'm genuinely okay." She paused. "Are you?""I've been waiting for this for, well for months," Richie said. "I'm — yes. Very okay."She turned toward him. He tightened his arm around her. She could feel him breathing.*I am still. I can hear his

heartbeat.*HalloweenJoe's Bar — October 31, 1991Methos Runs a Calibration

Methos Runs a Calibration

It started on a Wednesday in October. The bar was in the comfortable mid-evening state — not full, not empty, the band not yet performing. still becoming Methos had been on his stool for forty-five minutes. He had consumed one beer, was working on his second, and had been reading something on his phone with the focused quality of a man engaged in serious intellectual work, which meant he was almost certainly doing something completely frivolous. Jennifer removed his feet from the bar. Methos looked up, at her and across the bar at Richie. He was on his stool with his coffee and was focused on everything Jennifer did. It had been that way for months. Methos looked back at his phone. Jennifer watched him, peripherally. He wasthinking about something, selecting something from his archive and put the phone down. Jennifer braced slightly. She had learned to trust the bracing."You know," Methos said, conversationally, to no one in particular, "I've been thinking about the great mythological traditions."Jennifer was wiping down the bar. "Mm," she said."The vampire, for instance." He turned his beer glass. "Tremendouslymisunderstood figure. The mythology is far older than most peoplerealize, predates Stoker by several thousand years, reaches back intoMesopotamia. I may have met one of the original inspirations. I was inthe region at the right time.""Mm.""The appeal is obvious. The immortality. The power. The —" He gesturedvaguely. "The neck thing."Jennifer kept wiping."Speaking of which," he said, and his voice acquired a specific qualityshe hadn't heard before, "I could bite you on the neck. If you wanted."Jennifer stopped stared at him. He looked back with complete composure."No," she said implying that Methos might be crazy."Three times," he continued. "If you wanted. I'm told the third time is —""No," Jennifer answered in a louder tone."The offer stands.""It does not stand."From Richie's stool, nothing. Jennifer glanced at

him. He had his coffee inboth hands and his jaw was set. She could tell he was exercising agreat deal of conscious control over whether to say something. She filed it and kept working. If Richie was unwilling to feed the troll she wouldn't either. Methos went back to his phone. Two minutes passed."The werewolf," Methos said, "is a different matter entirely."She did not stop wiping. It was going to count for her cardio for theday if Methos didn't leave or just stop."More complex symbolism," he said. "The transformation, the surfaceself and the true self in fundamental conflict, philosophically rich. Much more interesting than the vampire.""I try not to think about it," Jennifer replied nonchalantly."The transformation itself has a certain spectacle. I've seen someremarkable things in five thousand years, but a genuine transformation?" He shook his head with the gravity of a man who had witnessedgenuinely remarkable things. "Nothing quite like it.""Have you actually seen one?" she said, despite herself."That's classified," he said. "The point is, the offer stands. If you wanted to watch. The transformation. I believe I could arrange —""Methos," she demanded."Marsh," he said."No, all right? Just no." She moved down the bar. Richie set the coffee mug with precision, the way of someone who needed their hands to be free. Another two minutes passed. The silence had been golden."The selkie," Methos announced, "is under-appreciated."Jennifer had been restocking the speed rack. She paused and took a deepbreath. Jennifer wasn't sure who Methos was trying to get a rise out ofbut knew something was going to snap if this joke didn't end quickly."If you're so interested in Halloween and monsters, why don't you makeyourself useful and put up some decorations," Jennifer suggestedpointing to the table holding the same. Methos was unphased. "Scottish origin, primarily," he said. "Seal whobecomes human by removing its skin. The female selkie irresistible tomortal men. I was in Scotland in the relevant period. I may have knownone. The details are somewhat —" He waved a hand. "The mythology carriesa certain —""Methos," she all but barked."Marsh," he said flatly."Where is this going?"*Exactly where I intend it to go and you'll find out when I get there.*"I'm simply exploring the territory," he said. Jennifer went back to the speed rack. From Richie's stool there was avery deliberate, controlled silence."The ghost," Methos said, "presents certain logistical challenges.""I imagine it does," she said, not stopping."The unfin-

ished business aspect. Very inconvenient. I've always felt —""Methos. I'm working.""I can see that. You're very efficient. It's one of the things I findadmirable about you.""You're not making conversation," she said, still not stopping. "You'redoing something. I don't know what yet but I'm aware of it." He looked at his beer and almost smiled."The mummy," he said, "is my personal favorite."Jennifer stopped. She shouldn't have stopped. She knew the moment shestopped that stopping was information she was not supposed to give him. But the non sequitur of it — the mummy, his personal favorite, deliveredwith the specific gravity of a conclusion he had been building toward —landed somewhere her professional composure was not adequately defended."The bandages," he said, with great seriousness. "The specific —containment of the thing. The preservation. The —" He turned to look ather directly. "I could wrap you up, Marsh. Very thoroughly. Tight, tightbandages —"The sound that came out of her was not a laugh. She would not have called it alaugh. It was an involuntary exhalation of breath that happened to occurat a frequency associated with amusement and which she suppressedimmediately and completely, except for the two seconds in which it wasentirely visible to everyone in the bar. Two seconds. Richie's stool scraped the floor. Jennifer watched six feet of hunkyimmortal in a leather jacket get to his feet. He'd sitting still for twenty minutes and had decided that sitting still was no longer appropriate. "Methos," Richiegrowled. Methos turned. He looked at Richie with the full attention — the readingattention, the one that had been the whole point of the last twenty minutes."Richie," he said, pleasantly."You need to stop," Richie announced quietly. "I was discussing mythology," Methos said. "Educational content, Richie. Sit down, relax.""I'm not going to let you keep disturbing the lady as she's trying towork.""The lady," Methos sighed before looking briefly at Jennifer. "Yourlady?"Silence. Jennifer prepared a fresh coffee so Richie could have something new inhis hands. Then she turned to Methos and looked at him with the fullversion of her attention — the bar version, the one that had removed hisfeet from the bar twenty thousand times without breaking stride. "When youwant to know how either of us feel about something you can ask directly. Itwill be a faster process, more accurate and will have no need to dragmummies into the conversation." A pause. "Addi-

tionally, if I wanted to be wrapped in tight, tight bandages this would not be any of your business," she bit. "For therecord I would most likely panic resulting in a medical emergency. And as a close friend I know you would not want to see that happen to me."Another pause. "And none of offers stand. The neck, the transformation,the selkie situation, the mummy. None of them," Jennifer barked. "Ifthis continues I will have you tossed out of the bar tonight. Are weclear?"Methos looked at her. She held his eyes. He picked up his beer, drank itand said with great dignity, "The educational content stands regardless."And then he left the premisses without the police needing to be called. Jennifer picked up the bar cloth and went back to work. "What the hellwas that all about?" Jennifer grumbled."Just Methos digging for information," he sighed before offering her asmile. "You handled that well. You do have the authority to kick himout, even put a ban on his entry.""Yeah, but why not just ask? Why does it have to be a production all thetime," Jennifer grumbled. "Jennifer and Richie are you datingofficially? Does Jennifer like being tied up with mummy bandages? Sojuvenile."After a minute Richie questioned, "So, the tying you up with mummybandages, is that out of the question then?""Actual mummy bandages? No, gross," Jennifer answered firmly. "But TUNAwith you would be fun, just not my wrists." Richie made some notes andsmiled at her. My lady. Later that evening Methos was enjoying a cup of tea and quite pleasedwith the information he had wrung out of the both of them. Richie haddrawn the line at Jennifer's discomfort. Jennifer was able to gain herauthority at the bar. The kids were going to be all right. HalloweenJoe's Bar — October 31, 1991

Halloween

Jennifer's costume was a pair of cat ears on a headband. That was it. That was the whole thing. She put them on at the start of her shift and they sat on her head. When Mac arrived he was in full Highland dress. He was nonplussed with the cat ears. "That's it? Good

thing you didn’t overdo it, Jennie.”“Wouldn’t think of it,” she returned while pouring him a drink.“Not even a tail?”"I'm a bartender," she said. "A tail is a liability."Mac looked at the cat ears. He looked at her. He had the expression of a man who had been on this earth for four hundred years and had never encountered anything quite like Jennifer Marsh's relationship with Halloween."Very committed," he said."Thank you," she said. She went back to work. Richie came in at eight in a leather jacket, white t-shirt, jeans, and sunglasses he was wearing indoors at night."You're not in costume," Jennifer said. He pointed at the sunglasses. She shrugged. "James Dean," he said.“The both of you,” Mac commented. “One with a headband, one with a pair of sunglasses but no Halloween spirit whatsoever.”“I’m James Dean," Richie said again, with the full commitment of someone who had decided this was the hill. Jennifer considered the sunglasses. She looked at him. She put a coffee in front of him without being asked. "You're lucky you're pretty," she said before looking at Mac. “You as well.”Richie smiled and left the sunglasses on. The look was working. Amanda arrived at nine in something that was historically specific to a period she had actually lived through, was impeccably researched and devastatingly beautiful. She swept in the way Amanda swept in and the bar reorganized itself around her entrance the way rooms always did. She looked at Jennifer's cat ears."Inspired," Amanda said, with complete sincerity."Thank you," Jennifer said."Minimal. Practical. Makes a statement without committing to one.""That's the goal," Jennifer said. Amanda smiled at her with the full warmth of someone who had just decided something. She went to find Mac. Methos arrived at nine-thirty. He was dressed as a specific Roman senator from the late Republic period. Not a generic toga situation — a specific senator, with the stripe of rank on the toga, the actual style of sandal appropriate to the period, the signet ring, the way a man of that class and era wore his toga in public versus private settings. Methos had done this completely and without irony and he had, in the manner of a man arriving at a gathering where he expected to be the most knowledgeable person in the room, prepared remarks. He stood in the doorway. Joe looked at him."Who are you supposed to be," Joe said. Methos said a name in Latin. Joe looked at him."Marcus Aemilius Lepidus," Methos said. "Consul 46 BC. Member of the Second Triumvirate. Often over-

looked in favor of Caesar and Antony despite playing a significant role in the political restructuring of the late Republic, which frankly —""I'm going to stop you," Joe said."— says more about the historiographical bias toward military figures than it does about Lepidus's actual importance," Methos said."I'm going to stop you," Joe said again. Methos stopped. He looked at the bar. He looked at Jennifer's cat ears. He looked at Richie's sunglasses."James Dean," Richie said, preemptively. Methos looked at the sunglasses for a long moment."The toga," Jennifer said, with the flat voice at the genuinely interested setting, "is that the actual drape for a man of his rank or a theatrical approximation."Methos looked at her. Something moved through his face — the expression of a man who had been waiting for someone to ask this exact question and had begun to despair of it happening. "Actual drape," he said. "The theatrical version bunches at the shoulder which is historically inaccurate. The correct drape falls —""Methos," Mac said."She asked," Methos said."She's going to regret asking," Mac said."I'm not regretting anything yet," Jennifer said. She leaned on the bar. "Tell me about the ring."Methos sat down at the bar. He put his arm on the counter. He showed her the ring. Joe looked at the ceiling. He looked at his guitar in the corner. He looked back at Methos explaining a Roman signet ring to Jennifer Marsh at eleven o'clock on Halloween night while wearing a full Republican-era toga in a bar in Seacouver."Only here," Joe said, to no one."Only here," Mac confirmed. Richie, in his sunglasses, drank his coffee. Fitz, who had arrived at some point dressed as a swashbuckling pirate because Fitz was always essentially a swashbuckling pirate and had simply leaned into it, was playing the tambourine in the corner. Amanda was explaining something to a customer who had made the mistake of asking about her costume. The customer looked very engaged and slightly alarmed. Jennifer was listening to Methos explain the signet ring. She filed all of it. All of it went in her journal. Outside, Seacouver did its Halloween thing. Inside Joe's bar the late Roman Republic was being accurately represented and nobody was going to stop it.

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Not ThanksgivingAmanda's Apartment — Late November 1991

Not Thanksgiving

Amanda did not do Thanksgiving. She had made this clear to Mac in approximately 1983 and had reiterated it at intervals since. She was not American. She did not celebrate the systematic dispossession of indigenous peoples through the medium of a turkey. Amanda had opinions that she expressed when asked, sometimes when not asked and that was that. She called Jennifer on the Monday before Thanksgiving."I'm having dinner on Thursday," she said. "You should come.""I thought you didn't do Thanksgiving," Jennifer said."I don't," Amanda said. "I'm having dinner. On a Thursday. In November. It's a coincidence."A pause."What time," Jennifer said."Seven," Amanda said. "Wear something nice. Not black. You always wear black.""I wear black because I work in a bar," Jennifer said."Thursday you don't work in a bar," Amanda said. "Thursday you come to dinner. Seven o'clock. I'll text you the address."She hung up. Amanda then called Mac. "I'm having dinner on Thursday," she said. "You're coming.""You don't do Thanksgiving," Mac said."Duncan.”"Seven," he said. "I'll bring wine.""You'll bring good wine," she said. "Not the scotch you always bring when I say wine.""Amanda.""Not the scotch.”She called Joe. She called Richie. She did not call Methos. She texted him. The text said: Dinner Thursday seven. Don't wear the toga. His response was immediate: Which toga. She turned her phone off.* * *Amanda's apartment was on the fourth floor of a building that had been built in 1932 and had never once apologized for its architecture: high ceilings, crown molding, windows that went floor to ceiling and looked out at the city. The furniture was specific and chosen. Nothing in the room was accidental. Amanda had set the table with actual linens and the candles were tapers in silver holders. The wine glasses were crystal and there were place cards written in beautiful script. Jennifer stood in the doorway and looked at the table."Sit any-

where," Amanda said, coming from the kitchen in an apron that cost more than Jennifer's monthly food budget and somehow looked completely natural on her. "The place cards are for my own amusement. You can ignore them."Jennifer looked at the place card at the seat nearest the window. It said The Empress in Amanda's handwriting. She sat there.* * *Amanda had made the beef bourguignon herself. She had started it on Wednesday. It was the kind of beef bourguignon that required starting it the day before serving and the aroma that filled the apartment that made the concept of Thanksgiving feel like a reasonable idea, even to people who had strong feelings about the holiday. Everything else had been sourced. The bread from the French bakery on Clement. The salad from the place on Morrison that did it correctly. The potatoes had a specific preparation that Amanda had attempted to replicate twice and had decided instead to simply order. The dessert — a tarte tatin — from a patisserie that Amanda had driven forty minutes to reach."You made the main," Jennifer said. "And ordered the rest.""I made what I make well," Amanda said. "And sourced what others make better. This is wisdom, not laziness.""It's extremely wise," Jennifer said."Thank you," Amanda said, with the warmth of someone being correctly understood.* * *Methos arrived in a coat that was not the toga but had a similar energy. He looked at the table, at Amanda. He looked at the beef bourguignon. “1962," he announced. "The wine in the braising liquid or close to it.""1961," she said. He nodded and sat down. Methos had eaten the bourguignon enough times to know that it was going to be excellent. Mac brought the right wine, two bottles. He set them on the table without comment. Amanda looked them over and said nothing, which was everything. Joe arrived last with a proper arrangement, the kind that required a florist rather than a corner store. He put them on the sideboard with the matter-of-fact grace of a man who had been doing thoughtful things quietly his whole life. Jennifer looked at the flowers and then at Joe. "Happy Thanksgiving.”"I'm having dinner," Joe returned with a smile.. "On a Thursday, in November."* * *The dinner lasted three hours. Not because the food was slow, Amanda ran a table efficiently, but because nobody wanted to leave the table. The beef bourguignon was incredible, the wine was correct and the bread was fresh. The conversation moved the way it moved when the right people were

in the right room; from the serious to the absurd to the quietly personal and back, without effort, without anyone managing it. Methos told a story about a Thanksgiving dinner he had attended in 1842 that had devolved in ways that he declined to fully specify but that had apparently involved a dispute about gravy and three people who were never seen in that county again. Mac told him to stop. He stopped, mostly. Fitz — Amanda had called Fitz, because of course she had — did three things with a napkin that made Jennifer laugh until she had to put her wine glass down. Amanda watched this with the expression of someone confirming a hypothesis. Richie, at some point in the second hour, said something to Jennifer in a voice too low for the table to hear. She looked at him. She said something back. He nodded. Whatever it was stayed between them. Joe watched the table. He had the expression of a man who was doing the thing he always did — filing it, keeping it, adding it to the chronicle that nobody had asked him to keep and that he kept anyway because some things deserved to be remembered by someone. At some point Amanda looked at the table and had a brief, unguarded expression of a woman who had been putting together rooms full of people and occasionally had gotten it exactly right. She picked up her wine. "To the people at this table," she said. Crystal wine glasses clinked and they all drank. The tarte tatin was magnificent. Amanda accepted the compliments with the composure of someone who had driven forty minutes and was entitled to them.* * *The next morning Amanda intended to take Jennifer shopping. It had not been discussed in advance. No one had been expecting her. Richie was partially dressed and took his sword to the door. Jennifer was right behind him similarly clothed. “I think it’s Amanda,” she whispered. It felt like Amanda and she definitely would not have had any trouble getting the building door opened.“We don’t know that,” Richie returned before urging her to retreat. Richie pulled the door open and indeed it was Amanda prepared to strike down whoever it was that had gotten to Jennifer. “Oh, it is Amanda. Hi, Amanda, please come in,” Richie sighed as he lowered his rapier.“I should’ve known,” Amanda sighed as she put her weapon aside.“Who wants coffee?” Jennifer asked quickly as she went to the kitchen. Richie pulled on a t-shirt and went to assist Jennifer. “So, what brings you here unannounced this morning?” Richie questioned. His

morning plans had not included visitors.“I came to take Jennifer shopping,” Amanda announced as she curled herself up to sit at a coffee table. It was the only table available. It was ridiculous. “How long has this been going on?”“How long has what been going on?” Jennifer questioned before serving them each a cup of coffee. “I don’t know what you’re talking about.”Amanda thanked her for the coffee and nodded. “I see. Clearly there’s nothing going on here then,” she sighed getting the picture. “Does anyone else know?”“No and we’d like to keep it that way for now,” Richie answered.“To the grave, you have my word,” Amanda returned smiling at the both. “So, who wants to go shopping? We could start at a furniture store.”Chapter Eight WinterChristmas Eve and Day

Christmas: Eve and Day

Richie told her about the Christmas plans a week ahead of time. It wasn’t a warning so much as it was an informational session on what to expect at Joe’s house for the holiday. They were at the dojo after the kids' classes. Mac was in the office, Jennifer was sweeping and Richie was stacking the practice mats. "Joe's on Christmas Eve," he said. "You should come."“I’m planning on it.”"I know, I’m glad, but you need to know it’s not going to be the movie version of Christmas.” Jennifer paused and looked at him. "Joe doesn't do presents, he does presence. There's a difference."“Christmas just wouldn’t be Christmas without any presents,” Jennifer quoted as she continued with her sweeping. “Well, all right, we do play the gift exchange game and sometimes people bring gifts but it’s not required,” Richie explained. Jennifer assured him she was familiar with the gift exchange game and had been saving an item for an occasion like that. Richie leaned closer to her. “Mac usually gets quiet at some point. Not bad quiet, just — let him." She filed it. “And Methos will say something that sounds cynical and means the opposite.""That's just Methos," Jennifer sighed."And Joe has a rule. If you come on Christmas Eve you stay until three the next day,

no one on the roads. That's just the rule."She thought about this. It was a reasonable rule. “So what should I bring for the table?”“Just yourself. Joe has it covered, trust me.”* * *Mac had offered Jennifer a ride to Joe’s in the late afternoon of Christmas Eve and she accepted. Jennifer was outside of her building when he arrived. Mac stepped out of the car, took her bags and set them in the trunk. From there he picked up a small wrapped package and told her to hold it while he got her settled in the car. When Mac was back in the driver’s seat he told her to open it. “It’s just a little something I thought you might enjoy,” he announced. “You can open it now. There’s not really a formal gift giving situation at Joe’s.”Jennifer opened the gift and found a Rhodia, a real honest orange, Rhoda notebook. “Oranji-san!” she nearly squealed. “Oh, this is top of the line. Wow, Mac, thank you.”“Well, if you don’t like it you can exchange it,” Mac commented dryly. He was glad she liked it and imagined she’d fill it up with pages and pages of notes on everything.“I’m sorry to say I didn’t get you anything.”“You spent all your money on Richie,” he chuckled. “Besides, your presence is the present, Jennie.”Mac and Jennifer were the first to arrived and took the best parking spot to the side of the house. It was a large house, a Colonial, with a set of stairs and a wrap-around deck. Mac had a bottle he was bringing along with a drop kit and Jennifer had her overnight bag and a large wrapped present. “Are you sure you don’t want help with that?” Mac questioned as Jennifer slid a bit on the ice. “I’ve got it, Sensei. Balance for whole life.” Joe saw them coming up the stairs and opened the door. “Well, look who’s here. Merry Christmas,” Joe greeted.“Merry Christmas,” Jennifer returned as she wiped her feet. “I need a place to hide this until tomorrow morning.”Joe pointed to the interior stairway. “First door on the left. There should be room in the closet.” Jennifer thanked him, took off her shoes and raced up the stairs.“Happy Christmas,” Mac greeted as he handed Joe a magnum size bottle of whisky.“Merry Christmas, Mac,” Joe returned. “Think this will hold us?”“I’ve got another in the car,” Mac commented as he took a seat on the couch near the tree. It was fully decorated with colorful lights and sparkling tinsel. “Tree looks good.”“Thanks,” Joe returned as he poured a dram for Mac. Jennifer descended the stairs with the same amount of energy and plopped down next to Mac. “All set with the closet?”“All set,” she confirmed.

“Richie’s going to love it,” Mac commented with a smile.“What are you drinking tonight, kid?”Jennifer wanted coffee. She sipped it as she looked around the living room. The tree was in the corner by the window, real, a Douglas fir that had dropped needles onto the hardwood. The lights on it were the old kind, large colored bulbs, and ornaments were stacked up in boxes ready to be deployed. “Are we trimming the tree?” Jennifer questioned.“Later, after carols.”Methos was the next to arrive and he handed Joe a unique bottle of spirits upon greeting him. Joe asked what it was and Methos simply stated it was whisky. “From where?” Joe questioned."A place," Methos replied. "Don't ask questions."Amanda arrived ten minutes later with Fitz. He had been in Seacouver since Wednesday and had spent two days trying to talk Mac into something involving a Christmas market in Vienna. Mac had declined on grounds that were never fully specified."He's being unreasonable," Fitz said as he took his coat off."I'm being very reasonable," Mac called from the couch."Vienna," Fitz said. "At Christmas. The markets, Mac. The —""We have everything we need here.”Jennifer silently disagreed. Richie wasn’t there and she kept checking her phone to see if had messenged her. Once everyone was seated with a drink in hand Fitz said something about Christmas in the seventeenth century. Mac corrected him on a detail. Methos corrected both of them without looking up from his book. Amanda told all three of them that their respective memories were unreliable. She had been there, they had not and her version was correct. Jennifer was fascinated. “Were you actually there at Christmas in the seventeenth century?” "Several of them," Methos said, without looking up."Which one are they arguing about?""1643," Methos said. "England. The Christmas celebrations had been suppressed by Parliament. There was a riot in Canterbury.""Were you in Canterbury?""I was adjacent to Canterbury," Methos said. Jennifer looked at Mac and asked, “Were you in Canterbury?""No," Mac said. "I was in Scotland.""Then why are you arguing?”The next thing Jennifer knew there was a throw pillow in her face holding Mac’s reply. She caught it, barely. “Good reflexes, Marsh. Nage-makura is an advanced technique.”She looked to Mac for an explanation. “Thrown pillow,” he announced. “Not throw pillow.”Jennifer nodded and squished the pillow with her fingers before setting it behind her back. “Thank you, Sensei.

This new discipline will complement my lessons in Broom Fu."Before she could say anything more her pager beeped. 209-20. Richie was running late but on the way. He was fine. He was safe. Mac felt the tension run out of her body and smiled. "On his way?" he questioned. She nodded with a small smile. "Good. When Richie finally gets here we can eat." Twenty minutes passed before Richie arrived with a small bag. As soon as he was settled Joe called everyone to the table. It wasn't as lavish as Amanda's No Thanksgiving table had been but it was warm and cozy. Joe had prepared a mixed feast that honored his English roots and what had bloomed in America. There were crackers, not saltines, but the English kind that exploded when tugged and delivered little treasures. A large turkey was the main course. Mac did the honors and carved the bird. Jennifer learned this was a tradition. Several bowls of roasted vegetables were passed along with bread, cranberry sauce with cloves and pudding. Platters of Christmas cookies and two different pies were served after the meal along with coffee, tea and additional spirits.

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During the meal everyone had been allotted a chance to secretly set their white elephant gift on the coffee table in the living room. After the feast it was time to play. Joe announced that the oldest among them would go first and reviewed the rules. Methos drew first. He selected a small box and opened his gift without hurry. Inside was a kazoo. "No," he said looking amongst the gathered trying to determined who had actually offered a kazoo as a gift. No one admitted to presenting the kazoo as a gift. It was yellow, plastic and entirely too cheerful."Lovely tone on those," Fitz offered. "Very — resonant.""I don't play kazoo," Methos said."Nobody said you had to play it," Mac said, carefully."Someone put this here," Methos said. Not a question. "And it's not as funny as you think it is."Amanda was not interested in the kazoo. She opened a bag that clearly held a bottle and it turned out to be a 1962 Bordeaux. Methos had identified in approximately three seconds as something he needed more than she did. Fitz stood, stretched, assessed the remaining pile with the air of a man who

had spent several centuries getting exactly what he wanted and picked up Amanda's wine bottle without breaking stride."That's mine," Amanda said."Was yours," Fitz confirmed, cradling it. "Rules of the game, love.""Fine," she said, in a tone that meant the opposite of fine and also meant she was already identifying her next target. Amanda stood, moved to the pile and selected a flat rectangular gift wrapped in silver paper with a very good bow. Amanda undid the bow first, carefully, and set it aside. The paper came off in one piece. Inside was a framed print — a botanical illustration, wildflowers, the kind of thing that ended up in antique shops and occasionally, apparently, in white elephant exchanges. Amanda looked at it for a long moment."It's beautiful," Jennifer said, honestly."It is," Amanda agreed. She looked at it for another beat. "It's absolutely not mine."Mac stood. He looked at the remaining gifts for a moment and selected one that had been wrapped in plain brown paper with a single piece of twine. Inside he found a bottle opener; an extremely good one, weighted, the kind that looked like it belonged behind a proper bar."I'll be taking that," Joe announced pointing to the bottle opener. Joe put his hand out and Mac gave it to him. "Thank you.""Happy Christmas," Mac said, and sat back down. Mac picked up a rectangular gift and opened it to find a paperback. Jennifer could see where she was sitting that it was a history of something, she couldn't read the spine. "Who's next?"Jennifer and Richie looked at each other."Youngest goes last," Amanda said, with the authority."Great," said Richie. "Jennifer first.""I'm older than you," Jennifer argued."Biologically," Richie said, immediately. Jennifer turned to look at him fully. "What other kind of older is there?" Richie appeared to consider whether to have this argument in front of everyone and decided that he had, in fact, wanted to have this argument in front of everyone. "I've been twenty for three years.""That's not how age works.""It's exactly how age works. I have more experience of being twenty than you do.""That is the most —" She stopped. Started again. "You're arguing that you're older because you've been stuck.""I'm arguing that I have seniority.""In what?""In being this age," Richie said, as if this were a formal category with an established hierarchy. Fitz was looking at Richie with the expression of a man watching a younger man do something Fitz himself had done and lived to regret. Methos put the kazoo

to his lips. Everyone looked at him. He took it away without playing it. “I was going to make a point,” he said, “about how neither of your arguments holds up over a sufficient timeframe, but —” He turned it over in his hands, and his eyes moved briefly, almost involuntarily, to the assembled men with an expression that landed somewhere between suspicion and certainty, “— I’ve decided against.” He set the kazoo on the arm of the chair. Let it sit there. “Jennifer goes first. She’s older. Age is biological. Everything else is philosophy.”Richie opened his mouth. “You can argue with me,” Methos said pleasantly, “or you can wait thirty seconds for her to open a gift. I’d suggest the gift.” Richie closed his mouth. Jennifer looked at Methos, who was looking at the kazoo again with the patient, quiet expression of someone who had identified the culprit and decided that the sentence would be delivered at a time of his own choosing. Jennifer stood at the pile and looked at what was left. Two gifts. One was small, spherical — something had been wrapped inside a box that didn’t fit it properly and the wrapping was doing its best. The other was a flat square, which could have been anything, and had been wrapped in what she was now close enough to identify as the Comics page from a Sunday newspaper. She did not say anything about this. She picked up the small spherical one, which had been her instinct from the start, and the room shifted almost imperceptibly in the way that rooms did when everyone present knew something the person in the center did not. Jennifer noticed. She kept going. Inside the too-large box, nested in a quantity of tissue paper that suggested someone had had fun with this, was a snow globe, not a cheap one. It was heavy, glass and the globe itself sitting on a dark wooden base that had a slight warmth to the finish — walnut. Inside the globe was a small city and the city had a bar on one corner of it. When Jennifer tipped it, the snow moved the way snow moved slowly with each flake finding its own path. Jennifer stood there with it for a moment. She was not, as a rule, a person who stood quietly with objects. She filed things, assessed them and moved on. But this one — she turned it over once, let the snow clear and tipped it again. “Oh,” she said. That was all she said. Just the oh, flat and genuine, the sound of someone who has been caught off guard by something small. Amanda looked at the snow globe with the appraising gaze of a woman who recognized a good object when she saw one

and was making a calculation. Jennifer, who had also spent enough time watching Amanda to have developed a functional early warning system, turned slightly so her body was between Amanda and the globe without making anything of it. She set it on her knee, both hands on it, and looked up. “Right,” she said. “Nobody touch this.”“I wasn’t going to touch it,” Amanda said.“You were doing the thing.”“I don’t have a thing.”“You have a very specific thing,” Jennifer said pleasantly, “and it was pointed directly at this.”Fitz choked on something. Mac put his hand over his mouth in a way that had nothing to do with drinking. Amanda expression that traveled from affront through reassessment and arrived somewhere that might have been, in the right light, respect.“Fine,” Amanda said. “Keep the globe.”“Thank you.”Methos was looking at the exchange with the expression he sometimes had, the one that Jennifer had catalogued as use unknown. He glanced at the kazoo on the chair arm. He glanced at the men. Something moved across his face that was not quite a smile and not quite not a smile. He said nothing.“Last,” Richie announced, standing. He looked at the remaining gift, the one wrapped in the Sunday Comics. He looked at Fitz’s wine. He looked at Methos’s kazoo. He picked up the kazoo. The room watched.“Don’t,” Methos said. Richie turned it over in his hand. He looked at Methos. He looked back at the kazoo. He put it back down on the arm of Methos’s chair with the gentle deliberateness of someone making a principled decision.“Smart boy,” Methos said.“I want it noted,” Richie said, “that I could have.”“Noted,” said Joe.“The record reflects,” said Jennifer. Richie went for the last gift. The Sunday Comics gave way to reveal a flask. A good one, stainless steel, with a small engraving on the front that he had to turn toward the firelight to read. Richie read it. He turned it over once, the way Jennifer had turned over the snow globe. Some days you need the long way home. — J. Jennifer was looking at the fire. Richie looked at her for a moment with the expression he had when something had landed before he’d had a chance to construct a reaction to it, which was rare enough that Jennifer had learned to recognize it. “When did you —”“Before I knew you’d be last,” she said to the fire. “It’s white elephant. I didn’t know.”“You still did it.”“I was hoping someone else would get it,” she said, which was so obviously not true that nobody in the room even attempted to look convinced.

Richie held the flask in both hands, turned it once more so the engraving caught the light, and sat back down. “Right,” he said. “Okay.” That was all he said.* * *Joe had a guitar. This was not a surprise but there was something about seeing it come out of the back bedroom on Christmas Eve that shifted the quality of the air. It was an acoustic, a Martin. Joe settled into his chair with it, adjusted once, and ran a quiet chord to check the tuning. “Any requests,” he said, which was technically a question but landed more like an invitation.“The Holly and the Ivy,” Fitz said, without hesitation, the way a man says something he has been saying for a very long time. Joe nodded, found the key and played the opening bars softly. Fitz started. He sang it straight. No ornamentation, no performance. Just the words, the melody, the full weight of meaning behind them carried without calling attention to the carrying. The holly and the ivy, when they are both full grown —Mac came in on the second line. Lower, quieter, but there. He knew it the way he knew everything — completely, from the inside out, learned long enough ago that it had become part of the structure rather than the contents. Of all the trees that are in the wood, the holly bears the crown. The refrain. Joe’s guitar lifted into it and several voices followed —The rising of the sun, and the running of the deer —Methos produced the kazoo. Jennifer heard it before she fully registered what she was hearing — a sound that had no business being in the same room as Joe’s guitar and Fitz’s voice, a sound that was to music what a seagull is to a string quartet. It was not that Methos played it badly in the way a beginner plays badly. It was that he played it with full commitment in a key that bore no relationship to the key Joe had selected, with a rhythm that appeared to be operating on a different calendar entirely. Fitz stopped. Mac stopped. Joe, to his very great credit, did not stop. He held the refrain on the guitar with the fortitude of a man who had played through worse, though his jaw had tightened.—the playing of the merry organ —The kazoo continued. Amanda set her glass down and held out her hand. “Give me that.”“I’m contributing,” Methos said, not stopping.“You are not.”“It’s a group activity.”“Methos.”He played through the end of the refrain. Jennifer was watching his face. He was not enjoying it. He was not not enjoying it. He had the expression of a man executing a decision he had made earlier and intended to see through to its conclusion re-

gardless of casualties. The refrain ended. Amanda reached over, took the kazoo out of his hand with the clean efficiency of someone who had been taking things from people for a very long time. She broke it over the arm of his chair, the breaking made a small, definitive sound. Amanda dropped the pieces into the wastepaper basket by the fireplace. The room was quiet."Second verse," Joe said. The holly bears a blossom as white as the lily flower —It was on the second verse that Jennifer heard Richie. She had been aware of him beside her in the general way she was always aware of where Richie was in a room — peripheral, constant, the specific gravity of him she'd stopped noticing as a separate thing because it had become part of how she navigated space. But on the second verse she actually heard him. He knew every word.—and Mary bore sweet Jesus Christ to be our sweet Saviour. His voice was not what she would have predicted. It was not a performance voice. It was just Richie's voice, the one he used to say things he meant, directed at the carol with the same quality he turned on things that mattered. Jennifer did not say anything about it. She just listened. Third verse. Fourth. The holly bears a prickle. The holly bears a bark. The room warmer than it had been, the fire lower, Joe's guitar steady as a pulse underneath all of it. On the final refrain Methos sang, not loud. Not making anything of it. Just his voice, adding to the room's voice, baritone and dry and completely in key, as if the kazoo had been a separate matter entirely and had nothing to do with him. The rising of the sun, and the running of the deer ——the playing of the merry organ, sweet singing in the choir. Joe let the last chord ring out and then muted it with his palm, gently. The fire settled. Outside, Seacouver was doing its December thing. The Douglas fir had lost another small quantity of needles onto the hardwood and the colored lights held, red and blue and gold, making the room into somewhere that memory would return. Richie had the flask in his jacket pocket. Jennifer had the snow globe on the cushion beside her. Methos had nothing, and did not appear to mind. "Again?" Joe said."Again," said Fitz. The calling it a night happened gradually and then all at once, the way these things did when the fire had gone lower and the second round of carols had wound down and someone had made tea without announcing they were making tea and it had simply appeared. It was Fitz who said it first, which was fitting. Fitz had a long

history of being the person who named the moment.“Right,” he said, setting down his cup. “I think that’s me.”Which opened the question of where everyone was sleeping, which opened the question of the gifts, which opened the question Jennifer had been sitting with since approximately the second verse of Holly and the Ivy.“Before we sort the rooms,” she said, “I want to go back to something, the kazoo.”“Terrible business,” Methos said.“Wasn’t mine,” said Fitz. “I brought the cheese.”“I brought the Scotch,” Mac said.“I brought the champagne,” Amanda said, without looking up from her glass.“I brought the harmonica,” Joe said, which produced a moment of quiet because Joe’s harmonica had been Richie’s gift and Richie had the expression of someone who had just been correctly credited and was trying not to show it.“I brought the snow globe,” Richie said. Jennifer looked around the room. She did the math. It took approximately four seconds. She looked at Methos. Methos looked back with the expression of a man who had nothing to hide and was comfortable in that innocence.“You drew first,” she said.“I did.”“And you were surprised.”“Profoundly.” “By a gift you brought.”A pause. Very small. The size of a kazoo.“I brought myself,” Methos said. “As previously established.”“Methos.”“Marsh.”She looked at him for a long moment. He looked back. The wastepaper basket sat by the fireplace with its contents, which were no longer relevant but remained present as evidence. Something moved across his face. Not quite a smile. In the right light. “Goodnight,” he said pleasantly, and picked up his tea.* * *Joe’s room was Joe’s room, which was not up for discussion. Amanda claimed the upstairs guest room. Nobody commented on this, but Mac saw Jennifer’s reaction. While the others were discussing sleeping arrangements he leaned over and whispered, “Don’t worry about the bag. Father Christmas will make sure it’s under the tree in the morning.”Methos and Fitz announced they were taking the living room, which Fitz declared adequate and Methos declared sufficient, which were different things but arrived at the same place.“Basement,” Richie said, addressing the room generally.“Sure,” Jennifer said. Then, a beat later, with slightly too much enthusiasm: “I mean obviously, it’s the logical — yeah. Basement. Fine. That’s fine.”“There are extra blankets in the hall closet,” Joe said, with the tone of a man who had not heard anything in particular.“I’m going to make a pillow fort,” Richie said.

“Oh that’s —” Jennifer stopped. Recalibrated. “That sounds fun actually.”“Yeah?”“A pillow fort. On Christmas Eve.” She nodded, building toward something that was supposed to sound casual and was not landing as casual. “That’s a completely reasonable thing to do. Architecturally interesting. As a concept.”“Architecturally interesting,” Richie repeated. “Structurally,” Jennifer said. “The engineering of it.”“Goodnight,” Amanda said warmly and went upstairs. The basement was finished; a concrete floor covered by a rug, a pullout couch that had been made up at some point in the afternoon, a second couch that hadn’t. There was a small window at ground level that showed the bottom of the snowfall, flakes coming down against the dark. Richie made the pillow fort. He was, it turned out, serious about this. He pulled cushions from both couches and the spare blankets from the shelf, and constructed something with an actual internal logic, a low entrance, a back wall, a roof that held. Jennifer sat cross-legged inside it and looked at the architecture with genuine appreciation.“This is good,” she said.“I know what I’m doing,” Richie said. They sat in it for a while. The house was quiet above them, the fire upstairs reduced to nothing audible, the tree lights probably still on because nobody had turned them off. Richie reached into the inside pocket of his jacket.“Before I forget,” he said. It was small. A folded square of velvet, dark green, the kind of thing you used when something needed to be protected. He handed it to her. She opened it and was delighted. “Richie,” she giggled. “It’s a Strawberry Shortcake necklace.”He nodded. “I saw it and knew you needed to have it. You always smell like strawberries, my strawberry girl.”“Thank you,” she said, which was not sufficient but was what she had. “Guess I can’t change my shampoo or soap any time soon.”“Don’t even think about it,” Richie instructed before leaning in for a kiss. “Merry Christmas, Jen.”“Merry Christmas, Richie,” she returned after the kiss. “Will you help me put it on?” Jennifer pulled her hair up and out of the way. Richie placed the necklace and made sure the clasp was solid. The pendant inside settled against her collarbone and she held it there for a moment. “Are we going steady?” she asked. “I feel like you just gave me your class ring.”Richie looked at her with the expression he had when something landed before he’d had a chance to put a reaction together.“Yes, we’re going steady. Obviously.”She nodded. He nodded.

They continued kissing. Outside the ground-level window the snow came down. Obviously. Christmas morning started with the aroma of coffee which was Joe's doing. He was up early and moved through his kitchen with the specific contentment of a man who had people in his house. The buffet assembled itself across the kitchen table: sliced fresh fruit, sliced, strong coffee, tea in a proper pot and the fried dough. They were dusted with powdered sugar and still warm. "You made these," Jennifer said, holding one."Someone had to," Fitz said. "Tell me they aren't delicious.""I couldn't do that without lying," Jennifer replied after taking a bite. "My darling girl, help yourself and don't be shy. I can make more."A box of pastries materialized, and the whole table had the quality of abundance assembled by people who took abundance seriously. They gathered in the way groups gathered on Christmas morning, in layers — Joe first, then Fitz, then Jennifer with her coffee, Richie not far behind, then Mac, then Amanda, and Methos last, arriving with the expression of a man who had decided to be present and was being present on his own terms. The pendant was under Jennifer's shirt. Nobody could see it. She knew it was there. Father Christmas had indeed left two gifts under the tree. The tag on the bag stated it was for Richie. He looked at Jennifer before opening it. There was a pause in the room that rang much differently than the previous evening's white elephant had. Richie put the bag down carefully. He picked up his coffee. He looked at Jennifer with the expression he had, the one she'd learned."Merry Christmas," she said, to her cup."Jennifer," Richie pleasantly sighed."It just came out. I heard it was good."He looked at the box, at her and kissed her right there in front of everyone. "Thank you, I love it. We're definitely going steady now."The squad reacted in character except Fitz. He had missed several key developments by being in London. "Have I missed something?""Several things," Methos said. "Since approximately August.""August," Fitz said. "And nobody told me.""You were in London," Mac said."I do have a telephone," Fitz said."Fitz, Merry Christmas.""Happy Christmas, darling girl," Fitz returned with enthusiasm. Then Fitz stood and retrieved the flat package from under the tree with both hands, the ceremony from the previous night fully restored, and presented it to Mac with an expression of profound magnanimity. Mac opened it. He lifted out the spoon. It was a decora-

tive spoon with an enamel handle and some kind of crest or scene that had become illegible over the years. It had been traveling between them since 1857 in increasingly elaborate wrapping. By 1991 the wrapping alone took four minutes to get through. Mac looked at it and turned it over. "Aye," he said. Quietly. With feeling. "I haven't seen one of these since I was a wee lad."He ran his thumb over the enamel. Mac had the expression of a man holding something that connected him to something lost. The room was very still. Jennifer, who had been watching this, felt something move through her chest. She looked at Fitz. Fitz was watching Mac with the warm patience of someone who had given a meaningful gift and was receiving the meaning back."Mac," Jennifer said. Gently."Aye," he said. Still looking at the spoon."That's a beautiful spoon.""It is," he said. "It truly is.""Where is it from?"The longest pause."I have absolutely no idea," Mac said. The room detonated and Jennifer did as well once she put the pieces together. Jennifer looked at Fitz through her tears from laughing. "How long has this been going on?""1857," Fitz said, with the dignity of a man who had been waiting one hundred and thirty four years to see that face on someone who didn't know."What is the spoon?""We don't know," Fitz said."Where did it come from originally?""We don't know that either," Mac chuckled. He was holding the spoon. He was not putting the spoon down."Then how did it start?"Mac and Fitz looked at each other."He gave it to me," Mac said."He gave it to me first," Fitz said."You gave it to me in 1857," Mac said."You gave it to me in 1856," Fitz said."That's not —""I have documentation," Fitz said."You do not have documentation," Mac said."I have a letter," Fitz said. "It mentions a small gift. The spoon was the small gift.""The small gift was a book," Mac said. "The book came separately.""Methos?" Jennifer requested. "1857," Methos said, without looking up. "Mac gave it to Fitz. I was there.""You were there?" Fitz questioned."I was adjacent," Methos said. Mac pointed at Methos. "Adjacent," Mac said. "He's always adjacent.""The spoon," Jennifer said, because she needed to know, "is going back in the wrapping next year?""Obviously," Mac said."The wrapping takes longer every year," Fitz said. "Last year alone —""The wrapping is part of it," Mac said."The wrapping is the best part," Fitz said. Jennifer looked at the spoon in Mac's hand. She looked at the man holding it. She looked at the room. Break-

fast had reached the stage where cups were being refilled and nobody was in a hurry when Jennifer set down her coffee and looked at Methos with an expression that Richie, who was paying attention, recognized as the expression she had when she had found a line and was deciding whether to walk it. She walked it. Jennifer came into the living room with her coffee. Completely casual. The flat voice at the warmest setting."Happy Saturnalia, Mithros," she said. The room went quiet. Methos looked up from his book."It's December twenty-fifth," he said."Saturnalia ran through the seventeenth," she said. "I know. I'm a little late. I've been busy."He looked at her."I did some reading," she said. She proceeded to wish Mithros a very happy Saturnalia with several details slightly wrong. The dates slightly off. The specific rituals slightly confused with other festivals. The gift-giving tradition slightly muddled. Jennifer delivered it all with complete sincerity. Methos corrected her,gently at first. Then with more specificity as the errors kept coming. He couldn't help it. Five thousand years of knowing and she kept getting it just wrong enough that he had to say something. He was three corrections in before he noticed. She had called him Mithros every single time. He went very still. She looked at him with the flat voice and the full version of herself."Not quite as titillating as mummies and werewolves," she said. "Yet incredibly satisfying."Richie coming in on cue, “Did she just punk Methos?""Yes," Mac said. Methos looked at her for a long moment."Well played, Marsh,” he said. Just that. The Methos version of a standing ovation."That's my girl," Richie sighed with a smile. The Nintendo got set up in the living room after breakfast, which took some negotiation between Richie, the television situation and eventually required Mac’s assistance with the cables. And then it was running. The two kids sat on the floor playing with the new toy. At one point Jennifer made a noise in protest at something on screen. Richie said something mildly inflammatory she responded to by elbowing him without looking away from the game.NEW YEAR’S EVEJoe’s Bar — December 31, 1991

New Year's Eve

The crowd was mixed the way New Year's Eve crowds were always mixed;some people in formal dress who had somewhere else to go and had stoppedin first and some people in regular clothes who had nowhere else to be. The bar was full without being uncomfortable. Joe had put up lights; notelaborate — Joe-elaborate, which meant the right amount and no more,warm and specific, and exactly calibrated to make the room feel like anoccasion without making it feel like a production. Joe had brought in two temps for the night. New Year's Eve was not aone-bartender situation. Jennifer ran the main bar and the temps handledthe overflow. Everyone knew what their job was and did it. Richie arrived at eight in a blazer and his fashion choice provoked the proper response. Jennifer looked at him from behind the bar. 'You're wearing a blazer,.''It's New Year's Eve,' Richie returned with a smile.'You own a blazer?"'I own several things,' he said. 'You've seen my apartment.''I will be examining the contents of all of your closets on my nextvisit.'Jennifer set a reserved long neck in front of Richie and continued on toother customers. Mac came in at nine, and greeted Joe and Richie. Jennifer set his Scotchin front of him without being asked. Mac watched the room taking thedetails of an evening worth remembering, chatted with his friends andenjoyed his drink. The crowd warmed up considerably when the band started playing. * * *The smoke break happened around ten, in the natural gap between the lastbig rush before midnight and the long settling stretch that followed. Jennifer slipped out the back. The alley behind Joe's was narrow and lit by the single bulb above the back door. Jennifer leaned against the brick with her cigarette andpulled her jacket in closer by scrunching her shoulders. The muffledsound of the crowd came easily through the wall behind her. The door opened and Mac appeared. Helooked at the cigarette with the same expression he always held inregard to cigarettes.'Thank you for not mentioning it,' Jennifer delivered in her flat tone. 'What are you doing out here? You hate it out here.''I don't hate it,' he said. Jennifer's facial reaction declared otherwise. 'I find it suboptimal.'Jennifer decided she could live with suboptimal and smoked. Mac stood in the cold with his hands in his coat pockets. He had entered the

alley for a specific reason and was deciding how to begin. She watched him decide. 'Mac?''Tis I,' he said.'Are you about to give me the talk?' He looked at her. 'Birds and bees,' she said. Flat voice. Warmest setting. Mac stood in the alley for a moment. Even a man of his age was still occasionally capable of being caught. 'It occurred to me,' he said carefully, 'that the situation with Las Vegas —''The situation,' Jennifer echoed.'— the first trip,' he said. 'Alone. Together.' Mac stopped. He started again. 'I want to be certain you have everything you need. That you feel—' he paused '— prepared. And comfortable. And that if there's anything you require or any conversation you need to have, that you know —' another pause '— that I'm available for that conversation.'He said it with the dignity and meant every word.'That is the most careful version of the talk I have ever heard.''I'm aware,' Mac sighed, 'that this is an awkward thing to raise with a female student. I want you to know I'm aware of that.' He looked at the wall above her head briefly. 'I find myself in a — mixed position. Teacher. And something closer to —' he stopped. He looked for the word. Not the one that had come before, not caraid, the friend word — something further in. Something that had been true for a while and hadn't been labeled. 'Bràthair.' he said quietly. 'Something in thatdirection.'Jennifer took in the entirety of the moment. 'Say it again, please.' Mac repeated the word and she wrapped her ears around it. "Is there a gender appropriate opposite or is this a neutral word?"Piuthar-chelie might work in this circumstance," Mac announced before adding commentary on the word. He also promised to write it down for her, for her continuing journal.'Yeah, okay,' she replied softly. 'This sentiment goes both ways.''Aye,' he said. 'It does.'The alley was quiet except for the muffled crowd in the bar. Jennifer took a long drag and let it out slowly. 'I'm in a good place. I don't know what's going to happen in Vegas, Igenuinely don't. But with Richie —' she paused, finding the right words '— I feel safe. And I feel appreciated, more and more every day.'Mac was quiet for a moment. 'That's all I needed to hear.'Jennifer ditched the cigarette against the brick and then hugged him, both arms. Mac held her. 'I'm really glad you're in my corner, especially for the awkwardconversations.'He made a sound that was not quite a laugh and not quite something else. 'Go back inside. You're going to freeze out here.'Jennifer pulled back,

smiled and went inside. Mac stood in the alley for another moment. Bràthair. He had not used that word in a very long time. He had not had occasionto. He turned it over — the weight of it, the specific gravity of a wordthat meant what it meant in the language his bones still spoke. Bràthair. He went back inside.* * *The countdown started somewhere in the crowd organically spreadingoutward and the room found itself in agreement during the last tenseconds of the year. Ten. Nine. Eight. Joe at his end of the bar. Seven. Six. Five. Mac with his Scotch. Four. Three. Two. One. The room went up. The noise, the movement, the specific compressed joythat had been building toward the moment and had arrived. Jennifer was behind the bar and Richie was on his stool. He looked at her across the bar and she nodded. The room was going — noise, movement, people sharing affection, the band hitting something loud and celebratory. She came around the bar, just for a moment, and Richie kissed her. Not a peck, not a brief acknowledgment of the occasion but the kind of kiss that represented every trip to the skate park, every weekend spent together, fortune cookies and the Soundgarden necklace. The room was required to go on without them as they were briefly somewhere else. They came up for air and looked at each other slightly out of breath. 'Happy New Year,' Richie announced still with his arms wrapped around Jennifer.'Happy New Year," she returned with a smile. Jennifer went back behind the bar, back to work, like she had never stepped away. Like the whole kiss in front of the entire world had been completely normal. Because in actuality, it had been. Both Joe and Mac bore witness. 'Well, I guess it's official," Mac commented before lifting hisglass to toast the new year with Joe. "Happy New Year."* * *The crowd thinned after midnight. By one o'clock the bar was mostlyempty. The temps had finished and gone. Leon was running the last of theclose. Jennifer was at her spot at the bar with a coffee. Joe was at hisend. Mac and Richie were the last two on the stools. Mac moved one closer. Not making anything of it, just, closer.'Las Vegas,' he said. Quietly, not a question. Richie looked at him.'January sixth,' Mac said. 'First trip alone.' He turned his glass. 'Theconversation we had. Some time back.''I remember the conversation,' Richie said. Mac looked at him steadily,the teacher look, the one that was patient, complete and expectedhonesty. 'Gentlemanly conduct has been in full effect since No-

vember.'Mac went very still. 'November,' he said.'November,' Richie confirmed.A pause. Mac looked at his Scotch. He looked at the bar. He looked atJennifer at the far end, coffee in hand, talking quietly with Joe,entirely unaware of this particular conversation. She had allowed him to deliver the speech in the alley and had evoked a stronger bond out of it.'Before or after Not Thanksgiving?' Mac questioned. Richie just lookedat him. He said nothing. 'Before Not Thanksgiving,' Mac sighed.'Yeah,' Richie said. Mac sat with this. The bar was quiet. The last of the close happening inthe background, Leon stacking chairs, the specific late night sounds ofa bar winding down. 'I sat at that table,' Mac said, after a moment. 'At-Not Thanksgiving. For three hours.' He paused. 'And neither of you —''No,' Richie said. 'Not a word,' Mac said.'Not one.'Mac looked at his Scotch for a long moment. He had the expression of aman revising his understanding of a situation and finding the revisionentirely to his satisfaction.'Good,' he said. Simply. 'That's good, Richie. Discretion is good.'"'Better part of valor I hear.' Mac started to form a reply but stopped. "Happy New Year, Mac." 'Happy new year, Richie."

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